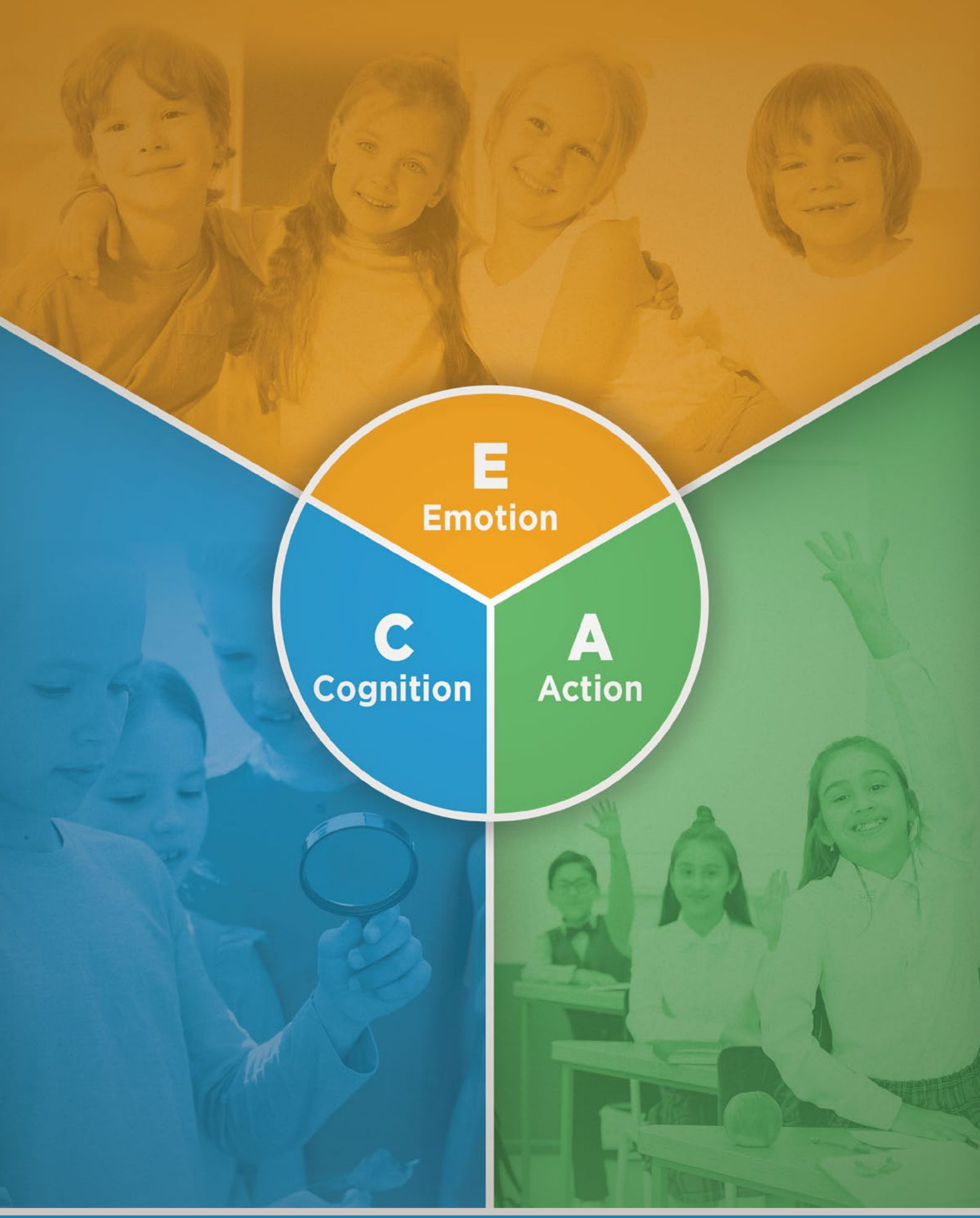


ECA Curriculum

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Pedagogical Principles of the ECA Program

ECA and Curriculum Priorities

Each curriculum decides its own priorities. This is how teachers, students and parents know what the given school is oriented towards. In Hungary, there is an alternative curriculum approved by the Ministry of Human Capacities, which is based on the development of social competences.[1] A detailed study has also been carried out on this subject, which shows how regulatory documents integrate the development of social competence.[2] The current curriculum also wants to belong to this group: it prioritizes emotional and social competencies. In our case, the ECA methodology makes the practical implementation possible.

But first, let's clarify what the ECA is. The ECA project is an international pedagogical collaboration of the Meseliget Foundation, which examines how emotional, cognitive, and action-based learning (Emotion–Cognition–Action) can be combined with person-centered pedagogical practice in order to make learning deeper, more personal, and more meaningful for students. This approach is based on an ancient approach, often described as the triad of body, mind and spirit, which is also known in the English pedagogical tradition as the model of „head, heart and hands". At the same time, the person-centered approach[3] által megalkotott személyközpontú megközelítés[4] created by Carl Rogers provides a very good philosophical background for this practice.

In our curriculum, we prioritize and detail the following:

- Emotional and social competence development
- Person-centred approach
- Creativity
- Sustainability
- Teacher self-development

Emotional Intelligence and Social Competencies in the NCC (National Core Curriculum) and ECA

The National Core Curriculum highlights the importance of developing emotional and social skills. Development is a cross-curricular goal, which is defined by the National Curriculum as an important area for lifelong learning and social inclusion.

Social competences are discussed in several places in the chapter entitled „Key competences and personality development". „Social and civic competence" is one of the key competences of the Hungarian core curriculum. Social-emotional development has an official place in this curriculum and is implemented in the framework of various school activities, such as holidays, headteacher classes, projects, camps, study groups and faculties.

The „Self-Knowledge" subject curriculum emphasizes the development of students' self-knowledge, self-criticism and self-evaluation, and helps students to consciously understand their own emotions and behaviour in community situations.

Person-centred approach

The person-centered approach focuses on the quality of human relationships and the values that guarantee this quality: empathy, unconditional positive regard, authenticity (congruence), trust and open communication. Carl Rogers was a psychologist and the founder of the humanistic psychological approach. His approach is based on the therapeutic situation that he experienced as a psychologist in his relationship with his clients: every person has the potential for development, self-realization and problem-solving, which can manifest itself best if their environment is accepting and supportive. Em-

1 2010-2014.kormany.hu
2 https://ofi.oh.gov.hu/tudastar/szocialis-kompetencia?utm ,
3 https://hu.wikipedia.org/wiki/Carl_Rogers
4 https://hu.wikipedia.org/wiki/Szem%C3%A9lyk%C3%B6zpont%C3%BA_pszichoter%C3%A1pia

pathy means that one party (be it a parent, partner or colleague) really understands and deeply empathizes with the other's feelings, thoughts, and life situation, and reflects this back to them. Unconditional positive regard ensures that everyone involved in the relationship is accepted with dignity and respect in their own values and decisions, regardless of their momentary behavior or emotions. Authenticity (congruence) means that the person is honest, open and shows their real self to the other, avoiding any manipulation or role-playing. These three principles create a solid, safe and trusting atmosphere in which the parties dare to express their feelings openly, dare to live their own experiences, as a result of which they get closer to themselves. The person-centered approach is universal, it can prevail in all deep human relationships, where attention to each other, support and mutual respect are crucial. This is how client-centered therapy became a person-centered approach.

The pedagogical aspects of the person-centred approach emphasize that the teacher-student relationship is a living, dynamic relationship in which the teacher is not only a knowledge transmitter but also a supportive facilitator. This approach recognizes the uniqueness of each student, respects personal development paths, and emphasizes self-study and self-reflection. During education, the teacher's task is to create an environment where students can ask questions, experiment and make mistakes with motivation and confidence, as learning from mistakes is essential for development. The authentic presence and unconditional acceptance of the teacher encourages students to develop based on their own experiences, feelings and thoughts, and not to adjust to external standards and expectations. This process not only promotes the acquisition of knowledge, but also promotes the complex development of the personality and the growth of self-knowledge and self-confidence.

Creativity

Carl Rogers left us the following thoughts: the world is changing faster and faster. We have to constantly adapt to this. Creativity plays a key role in adaptation. However, creativity cannot be enforced. We need to create an environment that supports and encourages its unfolding. One of the most important elements of this is unconditional acceptance, i.e. non-judgment, since the quality of a creative idea is still unknown at the given moment, it cannot be judged in advance as either good or bad. Only the creator of the idea can understand its value and potential, so it is crucial that students acquire a high level of self-assessment skills and are able to reflect on their own creative work authentically and confidently.

So it is worth devoting an appropriate amount of time and energy to this area as well. Creativity, like emotional intelligence, permeates the daily routine of teaching and requires space in every single lesson. However, it is also worth offering options to children as a separate lesson.

Sustainability

We must pay attention not only to human relationships during our lives, but also to our responsibility towards nature and the environment, as our health, well-being and the happiness of future generations depend to a large extent on the sustainability and health of the natural systems around us.

The integration of environmental education is aimed at developing an environmentally conscious way of thinking and laying the foundations for behaviour. We give priority to and set an example for the responsible use of natural resources, and we introduce students to the concepts of ecological footprint and global environmental challenges. By engaging practical sustainability projects, we make learning experiential, while using multidisciplinary approaches to ensure that sustainability education results in comprehensive knowledge and engagement.

Therefore, students are encouraged to actively observe and interpret environmental phenomena, as these are the basis of the students' world of experience. This also improves the skill of collecting and analysing data. At the same time, the conscious development of social skills such as cooperation, empathy and conflict management is essential for the success of group work and the acquisition of community norms. Their critical thinking and ability to make responsible decisions is established by asking questions and analysing situations where they need to consider alternatives and their consequences. So let's create a safe space for students and leave them alone so that they can work respectfully with each

other to create things they have never seen before, with which they can heal the wounds of our Earth.

Teacher self-development

The teacher's self-development is key in the transition to the ECA pedagogical approach. On a theoretical level, self-development means that the teacher constantly reflects on his or her own pedagogical practices, is open to new professional paradigms, and actively seeks opportunities to expand his or her own knowledge and competences, with special regard to supporting the learner's experience and autonomy. This approach goes beyond traditional frontal education and focuses on the person-centredness, where the teacher plays the role of a facilitator: it supports the active participation of the students, their creative problem-solving and their individual learning path. From a practical point of view, the transition requires teachers to learn new methods and tools, such as differentiated learning organisation, the design of experiential learning projects, and the effective use of technologies that support digital and live connections. In addition, it is necessary to consciously collect and incorporate student feedback into daily pedagogical practice, which continuously fine-tunes the educational process. Therefore, the self-development of the ECA teacher is a dynamic and integrated process, in which both the professional and personal development of the teacher is promoted, which in turn determines the student's independence, motivation and creativity, and creates a living, adaptive learning environment. In essence, teachers' self-development is the basis of student self-development: by experiencing the process, a teacher is able to empathize with the students' situation and create a safe learning environment for them.

The Traditional and the ECA Curriculum

Taking into account the priorities, let's look at the differences and similarities between the traditional and ECA curricula.

Curriculum chapter	Traditional curriculum	ECA-based curriculum (essence of change)
1. Objectives	Developing subject knowledge	In addition, priority will be given to the development of emotional intelligence and sustainability
2. Areas for development	Mainly cognitive focus	Social-emotional + cognitive balance
3. Content	Curriculum-focused	The most important learning materials will remain, but they will be experience-, project-, and action-oriented
4. Requirements	Knowledge reproduction, linked to the curriculum	In addition to the traditional requirements, there are expectations of behaviour, cooperation and self-reflection
5. Methodology	Teacher in control	Teacher facilitation, cooperative and creative methods
6. Learning Activities	Frontal + Task Sequences	It is based on student activity: active participation in planning, joint actions, self-assessment
7. Evaluation	Grades, exams	Developmental assessment, portfolio, self-evaluation, feedback
8. Number of hours	Fixed time frames	Flexible time frame, insertion of projects
9. Points of contact	Subject integration	Social-emotional learning interweaves the subjects
10. Curriculum organization	Linear, curriculum-oriented	Interest-tracking, experience-based, flexible
11. Differentiation	Based on Capabilities	Abilities and emotional state, cooperation, learning style and other aspects

1.
Objectives of the ECA Program

The facilitator's[5] attitude and toolkit

Our goal is that with the help of the curriculum and the related practical manual, teachers who undertake this can stand by the students in a supportive role, as a helper instead of a guide, encouraging independent learning and creative problem solving. This approach develops teachers' ability to adapt to different student needs, promote cooperation, and maintain motivation and emotional support. With facilitator tools, teachers are able to create a learning environment that encourages student initiative, active participation and personal development.

Developing emotional intelligence

The aim of the program is to enable students to recognize, understand, and effectively manage their own and others' emotions. This is facilitated by the development of the ability to recognize, understand, and control one's own emotions, as well as to connect empathetically with others.

David Goleman[6], the creator of the term, listed five areas here:

- **Self-knowledge:** awareness of our emotions
- **Empathy:** understanding and taking into account the feelings of others
- **Motivation:** perseverance in achieving goals
- **Social skills:** building relationships, managing conflicts
- **Self-regulation:** controlling emotions

All this is fundamental to the development of harmonious relationships and personal well-being, as well as to the ability of teachers and students to cope with stress and successfully adapt to changes in both school and social life.

Development of social competence

The development of this area aims to enable students to function effectively and harmoniously in community situations, to exercise empathy, to appreciate the importance of social relationships, and to develop their peer knowledge skills. Social skills are essential for self-awareness, emotional recognition and conflict management, all of which contribute to the development of a harmonious personality and successful social integration.

Developing student autonomy

Traditionally, the purpose of the school is to impart knowledge. The ECA program promotes the idea of the school being also a space for emotional and social development. School is the child's workplace, where he or she lives in cooperation with his or her peers, and this situation can be a place for the development of many skills that he or she may not be able to acquire at home. Therefore, our goal is for the child to gradually become the leader of his or her own learning. The teacher's task is to organize learning situations where the student can decide, plan, try, make mistakes and reflect – in other words, he or she can "practice" autonomy while being surrounded by a safe professional and emotional framework. Thus, with the ECA program, young people graduate from school with not only the curriculum in their head, but also have the internal tools that enable them to recognize and manage the uncertainties and burdens of everyday life.

Developing a relationship with democracy

The school can be an excellent place to strengthen the value of autonomy through one's own ex-

5 https://atanulasjovoje.hu/fokuszban_a_facilitator_kiadvany.pdf?utm_source=chatgpt.com
6 https://hu.wikipedia.org/wiki/Daniel_Goleman?utm_source=chatgpt.com

periences in early childhood. The child lives in the community as an emotionally involved, consciously decisive and active citizen with the help of the ECA teacher. In group assignments (e.g., a garden project), they learn to debate and reach a consensus, respect others, and assert their own voices without competing. This early autonomy – where the child chooses a task for himself, feels, thinks, cooperates and reflects – creates an intrinsic motivation for learning, acting and creating. This is the foundation for democratic values such as equality, participation, responsibility, and a sustainable community.

Strengthening intrinsic learning motivation

Our goal is for students to participate in the learning process independently and with heart and soul, to have an inner need to develop knowledge and skills. Positive feelings about oneself and identification with one's goals promote perseverance, creativity, and personal growth, thus providing a more lasting and deeper learning experience.

Through the processing of emotions and experiences, learning becomes motivating and interpretable, so both independent learning and creative problem-solving skills are strengthened.

Transfer of traditional knowledge

The purpose of the transfer of knowledge remains the same compared to the traditional school. The point is that students acquire basic knowledge appropriate to their age, interpret and apply it in everyday life. We have created the curriculum and the accompanying manual to make it easier to use the ECA method for delivering more complete cognitive content to students. This is how we can achieve that they are going to be happy to learn even when they are adults.

2.
Development requirements

Emotion

Involving students

The involvement of students in the formulation of development requirements can be a significant motivating factor. When students are involved in determining what they want to learn and how, they develop a sense of responsibility and commitment, as they are not just faced with a pile of expectations. Learning has a personal meaning. This approach helps develop self-reflection, supports independent learning, and promotes intrinsic motivation.

It is important that the teacher leads this process as a facilitator, creating a safe, accepting atmosphere where children can boldly express their opinions and needs. In this way, the developmental requirements can also be adapted to the individual needs and strengths of the students, which can result in more effective and joyful learning for all young students in the long run.

Don't be discouraged if your children get tired of thinking about the requirements after a while. Always leave the opportunity to join in, but don't force it. They may even leave the essence to us, as they can trust that if they don't like something, they can report it and initiate a change at any time. Many important conversations can arise in the meantime, which can prevent many conflicts.

Support instead of expectations

In the ECA approach, the focus of the formulation of development requirements shifts from emphasizing expectations to accompanying them on the road. It is also a change if we express the requirements in a language that encourages and strengthens the development of the students. This in itself can result in the creation of a positive learning atmosphere. The situation is the same with feedback: if we say it with a supportive attitude, they not only indicate shortcomings, but also motivate the student to develop their own skills.

Emotional and social indicators

In the area of emotional and social skills, the requirements need to be developed in much more detail, as we will do below. We cover behaviour, emotional awareness, self-regulation as well as social aspects: cooperation, communication, conflict management, etc.

Cognition

Skill – Ability – Competence

The most important task of the elementary school is to develop the three concepts in the title. The most important task of the teacher is to be aware of the diversity of teaching methods and to consciously apply them to encourage active learning among students. Such as presentation, explanation and illustration, as well as continuous question and answer, group work, project-based tasks, and the involvement of interactive techniques or the use of digital tools. The teacher's task is also to differentiate according to different learning styles, as well as to incorporate feedback and self-assessment. In addition, they must also think about their own development, look for opportunities for supervision, collegial exchanges or professional trainings.

Competence development in the first three to four years is aimed at establishing the basic learning skills of students. The development of emotional intelligence, self-regulation, and social and communication skills will play a key role. This is the traditional approach and the ECA also treats this issue in this way as well. And even more so!

Taking into account age-specific developmental needs includes the targeted development of basic skills in mathematics, writing and reading in accordance with the age characteristics of primary school students. Differentiated education allows teachers to provide personalized support to each student based on individual developmental characteristics, while project-based learning provides an experien-

tial, motivating framework for active participation. The methods of experiential education – such as field observations, cooperative games or creative activities – help to acquire complex concepts in an understandable and enjoyable way. The ECA curriculum has similar starting points. And even more so!

Primary school competence development is a complex, well-structured, pedagogically conscious process that focuses not only on the acquisition of knowledge, but also on the personal development, motivation and strengthening of students' community skills. This is how we give them a chance to achieve long-term success both in their studies and in everyday life. As we have seen, the goals of the ECA coincide with this.

So how does ECA differ from the usual one in terms of skill and competence development? Not in the goals, not even in the topics, but rather in the emphasis, the frameworks and the definition of the teacher's role: more time devoted to this, changed priorities (a higher proportion of emotional and social competences), non-directiveness in the methods. All this creates a system that is aimed at the parallel development of body, mind and soul in no other place than in school!

Teaching is closer to our training, habit, and teaching routine than facilitation, so it's easy to slip back into the traditional paradigm of thinking. We must pay attention to this – during the transition.

Subject development, linking the curriculum to experiences

In our curriculum, the curriculum does not change much compared to the traditional curriculum. The list of topics discussed will be somewhat narrowed and reduced, but the requirements will remain largely the same at this stage of development. So all we have to do here is to transform the school into a home that provides experiences, to transform it from a place full of tensions into a space that provides security.

Creativity

If we give more emphasis to creativity (or anything else) on the content side, this strengthening must also appear in the development requirements. Below is a list of general developmental requirements to help you comprehensively look at and consciously develop creativity in different dimensions. You can choose from these (and the list can be further expanded) in connection with a task.

Sustainability

This area is also not new compared to the traditional system. The difference is that traditional curricula consciously only call the relevant part of the curriculum in high school this way. The ECA curriculum is based on the fact that even with very young students, it is possible to consciously strive to protect our Earth. Therefore, we have developed detailed development requirements for this topic as well and incorporated them into the weekly teaching program.

Action

Individual development paths (choices)

A new element among the development requirements is the skills of the actions, which are partly related to the development of social competences, such as cooperation. At the same time, they also play an important role in supporting individual development paths. This means that not only do group skills develop, but we also need to encourage the formulation and development of individual goals and abilities. These individual formulations will be essential for the precise and personalized definition of development requirements.

Creativity and problem-solving

This area is implemented through practical activities that touch on all three areas of the ECA. If the teacher prioritizes creativity and regularly plans to develop it in the lessons, and their feedback is focused on reflectivity („What worked well? What would you change?"), mistakes appear as learning opportunities. We also evaluate the creative approach to a problem in the usual system, but the elaborate, detailed requirements for its development are usually scattered in the curricula. We have prepared a detailed list for this as well.

Summary of changes

So we can see that there are not many, but significant changes in the ECA development requirements.

- Competence development becomes a little more emphasized.

- The content requirements remain essentially the same, but the emotional and social dimensions, creativity and sustainability are covered in more detail.
- The teaching work is based on supportive, positive, reinforcing language.
- We build on the students' self-reflection.
- The flexibility of development requirements is important, which allows for differentiated progress tailored to individual needs.
- The involvement of students in the formulation of developmental requirements is the basis of all personal development.

Detailed development requirements for new items

Emotional intelligence

Self-awareness and emotional awareness

- They can recognize and name their own emotions in different situations.
- They independently carry out self-reflection and understands emotional states.
- They understand and manage emotional reactions and motivations in their own behaviour.
- They consciously integrate the connections between emotional and physical reactions.

Managing and regulating emotions

- They use stress management techniques on their own.
- They are able to strengthen positive emotions and manage negative emotions.
- They are able to exercise self-control in difficult or conflictive situations.
- They are able to consciously regulate impulses and sudden reactions.

Empathy and understanding the emotions of others

- They actively participate in accepting and respecting the point of view of others.
- They are able to show supportive and compassionate behaviour in difficult situations.
- They can recognize and correctly interpret the emotional state of others.
- They activate the ability to read emotional signals and nonverbal communication.

Relationship building and emotional cooperation

- They understand the importance of a safe emotional atmosphere in groups or classes.
- They are able to support shared emotional advancement and cooperation.
- They understand and manage emotional interactions consciously in communal situations.
- They independently recognize and empathize with the emotional side of conflicts.

Developing emotional communication

- They are able to express emotions openly and respectfully orally and in writing.
- They apply assertive communication with emotional content.
- They use the way emotional feedback is given and received appropriately.
- They recognize and manage emotional influences and communication.

Social competences

Communication and collaboration

- They can express thoughts and feelings clearly and respectfully.
- They actively participate in group work and joint tasks.
- They properly apply active listening and feedback techniques.

Empathy and understanding others

- They are able to recognize and interpret the emotions and needs of others.
- They express compassion and supportive behaviour towards others appropriately.
- They understand and manage the differences that arise in social situations.

Compliance with rules and norms

- They understand community rules and norms in everyday situations.
- They are able to adhere to and encourage others to follow common norms.

Autonomy and responsibility

- They are able to take responsibility for their actions in social relationships.
- They are able to make decisions and solve problems in community situations.

Conflict management and tolerance

- They understand the importance of tolerance and compromise in social situations.
- They are able to handle conflict situations in a constructive, empathetic, assertive way.

Networking and community engagement

- They are able to collaborate and contribute to community events and projects.
- They are able to show a helpful attitude towards those in need.
- They translate their skills into building and maintaining positive, supportive relationships.

Creativity

Although creativity appears as a subject, development cannot be held accountable. Thus, we only formulate guidelines that we can rely on during development.

Brainstorming and problem recognition

- They understand and manage different perspectives in their thinking.
- They are able to generate new, original ideas in different situations.
- They apply the search for alternative solutions to specific problems appropriately.
- They are able to recognize and detect problems and opportunities.

Thinking flexibility and innovation

- They are able to think flexibly and adapt to changing circumstances.
- They experiment on their own and try new methods.
- They integrate the ideas they have acquired and evaluate them critically.
- They creatively express ways to take risks and overcome fear.

Expression and implementation

- They continuously train themseles in creative work, individually and in groups.
- They use your ideas independently in visual, verbal, or other artistic forms.
- They are actively involved in creative writing or communication.
- They are able to plan and implement their own creative projects.

Developing individual creativity

- They are able to become aware of and develop their own creative process.
- They activate their endurance and independence during creative tasks.
- They are able to look for inspiration and incorporate it into their work.

Social creativity and collaboration

- They are able to manage and apply collaboration for creative purposes.
- They are able to absorb and develop the ideas of others.
- They understand and handle conflict in a creative way, seeking compromise.

Sustainability

Although the topic of sustainability has already been formulated in many curricula, we have prepared a relevant list for easier application.

Environmental awareness and knowledge

- They understand the limitations and importance of natural resources.
- They understand the impact of human activity on the environment.
- They are able to explain the basic principles of how ecosystems work.
- They apply environmental principles and rules properly.

Sustainable Living and Action

- They are able to make sustainable decisions in everyday life situations.
- They complete practical steps for waste reduction and recycling.
- They pay attention to energy saving and water saving.
- They are able to plan and implement smaller sustainability projects.

Social responsibility and community participation

- They are able to recognize their own responsibility for the sustainable development of the community.
- They support community environmental initiatives.

- They express their collaboration towards sustainability goals.

Critical thinking and problem-solving

- They apply problem-solving strategies creatively to sustainability challenges.
- They are able to look for alternative solutions in environmental situations.

Sustainability Assessment and Communication

- They are able to communicate your sustainability knowledge and suggestions to others.
- They track the impact of their sustainability activities and those of their community.
- They are committed to achieving sustainability in the long term.

3.
Contents

The triple unity of ECA

We have seen that during the practical application of the ECA approach, the teacher looks at the curriculum in three units, integrating the emotional (Emotion), cognitive (Cognition) and action (Action) aspects. The combination of emotional reinforcement, stimulation of thinking and the provision of opportunities for action strengthens the learning experience of students and ensures the stabilization of knowledge. In addition, emotional reinforcement increases motivation and the desire to learn. Stimulating thoughts is critical in developing problem-solving and creative abilities, fostering active student participation and deeper understanding. Action-based tasks allow the application of what has been learned, thus ensuring the long-term retention of knowledge.

Reflective questions support personal connection to the curriculum while practicing self-esteem. Interactive activities increase student participation and create a collaborative learning experience. Tasks that encourage action provide practical experience and play a role in the unconscious retention of knowledge. All three combinations result in complex development that strengthens students' critical thinking, self-reflection and practical application skills.

This multidimensional learning experience fosters complex understanding and a deeper connection with knowledge, and allows learners to understand what they have learned not only in theory, but also to apply it effectively in the future.

Emotion

Developing emotional intelligence

More than 70 years of happiness research conducted at Harvard University[7] has clearly shown that the quality of our relationships — that is, how well we are able to form and maintain harmonious, supportive relationships — has the greatest impact on our life satisfaction and well-being. And for this, we must also provide a suitable place in the school, where we spend 12 years.

Since this area is a priority in our curriculum, we will deal with its content elements in detail. If the teacher consciously incorporates this topic into their daily activities, it can effectively help the children to become confident and balanced adults later on.

Self-knowledge

Through self-knowledge, we have a better understanding of our own inner world, strengths and limitations, which helps us to orient ourselves more effectively in the outside world. Developing it makes us more aware of our emotions, thoughts, and behaviours, so we will be able to better handle challenges and shape our lives more satisfactorily. This deeper understanding helps us gain a more realistic view of ourselves, make better decisions, and build more harmonious relationships with others. It simply makes us happier and more balanced.

The area in question has a huge literature. There are many training and books about group and training games, but the best is your own experience! We can recommend the following:

- **Sándor Bányai** (https://www.kalandokes-almok.hu/): a professional workshop that focuses on personal development and publishes countless team-building games.
- **Catalyst Teacher Training Centre** (https://pedagoguskepzo.hu/elmenypedagogia/): which organizes accredited experiential education trainings.
- **Learning Zone** (https://tanulasizona.hu/elmenypedagogiai-kepzes/): it is also an accredited training opportunity, where you

7 https://semmelweis.hu/hok/2019/02/16/a-boldogsag-nyomaban/

can get acquainted with a lot of games that develop social competence. Its specialty is that it is held by outdoor trainers, who also actively involve movement in their program.

- **Experience zone** (https://elmenyzona.hu/kepzes/): they hold high-quality animator trainings with minimal equipment requirements.
- **Júlia Szekszárdi – Educational Handbook Not Only for Class Teachers** (https://ofi.oh.gov.hu/tudastar/nevelesrol-nem-csak): All of Szekszárdi's books are worth their weight in gold from our point of view. In this volume, we also get a lot of clues for getting started.

Reflective learning

Reflective learning provides the knowledge that can be used most in later adult life. In the course of self-assessment and self-reflection, we think about what we have learned, in which areas we have achieved success, and where we need further development. Reflective logs can be used for this. At first, questionnaires and series of questions can encourage students to express specific experiences and feelings about their own learning process. By incorporating feedback circles, such as pairs or small group discussions, students can share experiences with each other, gain different perspectives and develop their own thinking awareness skills – that is, how they monitor and regulate their own thinking and learning. This awareness supports students to become more independent and to use more effective strategies in future learning situations.

The use of reflective questions deepens the understanding of what has been learned and strengthens the personal relationship with the curriculum. In addition to empathetic guidance and continuous support, the teacher's task as a facilitator also sets an example in the presentation of desired behavioural patterns, including self-reflection.

Here we recommend some videos and studies:

- **Judit Szivák's lecture on reflective thinking:** https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=A3Pho50k2aw&t=25s
- **Dr. Tamás Csányi:** https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ZFw68ewT4r4&t=2s
- **Márta Hunya:** https://ofi.oh.gov.hu/en/node/170845 – This 2014 study is very good for getting acquainted with the topic
- **Iván Falus** (https://mersz.hu/dokumentum/m872d__180/?utm_source=chatgpt.com): theoretical foundations for learning to teach
- **Judit Szivák:** https://www.eltereader.hu/kiadvanyok/reflektiv-elmeletek-reflektiv-gyakorlatok/

Assertive communication

It is no coincidence that assertiveness, which is so popular today, is between aggressive and submissive communication. Its main topics are:

- **Self-assertion:** We are able to say clearly and unequivocally what we want, what we think or what we feel.
- **Respect:** We listen to the opinions and needs of others, we do not insult, attack, or manipulate.
- **Assertiveness:** We are not afraid of confrontation, but we do not seek it either, and we are able to say "no".
- **Confidence:** We are not afraid to defend ourselves, we do not suppress tension.

There is a vast literature on non-violent communication and conflict management. For a person-centred approach, we recommend the books of Carl Rogers, Thomas Gordon and Marshall Rosenberg – in their work we get answers to our most common questions.

Anger and stress management

As a factor influencing our happiness, we will also discuss this topic in more detail than usual.

The essence of anger management is that we make a "pause" between a sudden, strong emotional reaction (e.g. anger, frustration) and the action that follows, and we consciously decide what to do with the feeling. So we recognize the anger, which is not "bad" in itself, but a signal of a limit, a need or a grievance. What is important is to learn not to let the feeling turn into automatic, hurtful behaviour. The teacher has many opportunities to teach their class how to switch from mere reaction to the level of control, self-control, and responsibility.

A key competence for the ECA teacher is to see the emotional states and behaviour of the students

not only as a "problem", but as different reactions to stress, and to understand the internal processes of the given child behind them. To do this, it is necessary to recognize that children prevent tension in different ways, cope with it differently, and may have different strategies even in a crisis situation. Hit or run (or freeze) = emotions are necessary for survival – this is an ancient knowledge of ours. The task of an ECA teacher is to be emotionally available, boundary-setting and exemplary at the same time: to help students become aware of what is going on in them, how they can regulate their tension, and when new ways of solving problems, supportive relationships or professional help are needed.

Stress management is an integral part of our entire lives. The more we know about it, the greater our chances of developing a harmonious life. Even in early childhood, we can call on a lot of reassuring things to help. Developing positive routines can be one of the most important and rewarding tasks for teachers.

Some help:

- **Emőke Bagdy** https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=nSNUCzpWcak&t=102s – lecture on anger management
- **OTP Fáy Foundation:** https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Co-LL3LEzGA&t=11s
- **Ágnes Kozma:** https://mindsetpszichologia.hu/igy-szeliditsd-meg-a-duhodet-indulatkalauz-kezdoknek-es-haladoknak – summary article on anger management

Giving and receiving criticism

Giving and receiving criticism helps strengthen relationships. In the case of positive criticism, it is worth receiving the confirmation with gratitude, saying and experiencing joy. Strangely enough, in our culture, we also have to learn this. Giving negative criticism requires a responsible attitude: it is important to criticize the behaviour, not the person, the feedback should be concrete, loving, if possible, in person and in private. Let's listen to the other side's point of view and formulate what we expect from the change. Instead of fear, we should look at criticism as an opportunity for development. We should feel how difficult it is to formulate criticism, we usually struggle with this, and if someone takes the trouble to honour us with their trust, they deserve gratitude, even if what they say is unpleasant. Be open, if you can see the mistake, admit it, thank it, and look for a solution together, while taking responsibility and striving to improve. A small child can be grateful if his teacher starts teaching this incredibly complex and difficult science at an early age.

There is a lot of material on this important issue. It may be worth starting with these:

- **I'm learning myself series:** https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Arg3Sx_XQLY&t=993s
- **Dr. Rita Pécsi:** https://laudetur.hu/a-kritika-az-eletunkben-adjuk-is-kapjuk-is-hogyan-lehet-epito/

Responsibility

Taking responsibility is the key, we expect it from the children, but we usually don't teach it. However, this is also a teachable value, there are a lot of situations in school when we can catch it by the ear. Why not make this concept a curriculum, for example? We don't have to dedicate a separate lesson to it, just watch when there is a chance to teach more and more levels. It means taking responsibility to fix what we have done wrong, to offer compensation, to simply apologize, to admit our mistake and to promise to behave differently next time.

- **Gábor Pilát** https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=LfhVDYUlgSg&t=220s
- **Kata Harsányi:** https://pszichologuskereso.hu/pszichologia-blog/pszichologia-blog/a-felel%C5%91ss%C3%A9gv%C3%A1llal%C3%A1s-szintjei

Development of social competences

Let's get acquainted with a theory that is not so well known in pedagogical circles, although its accurate understanding is also a great help for teachers.

Schattenhofer[8]

According to this approach to group dynamics, the processes of the group should be examined in a coordinate system, where the upper area is the area of intimacy and community belonging, while the lower area is the

8 https://wiesnersnir.hu/wp-content/uploads/2023/06/Bevezetes-a-csoportdinamikaba.pdf

area of differentiation and the experience of individual differences. The theory emphasizes that intimacy must be strong enough to withstand the difficulties and conflicts that arise from difference. If we only put the emphasis on integration, then relationships become superficial, static, where we prefer to please each other but do not develop. At the same time, if we constantly emphasize only differences, we will experience a lot of conflicts, which will also make the relationship difficult. The alternation of the two – intimacy and differentiation – forms the basis of the deepening of the relationship, since only the existence of this dynamic balance ensures lasting, developing community relationships. This approach deeply understands and supports the complex, sometimes difficult, but enriching social processes that take place in groups.

Peer knowledge

Just as self-knowledge is a tool for getting to know our own inner self, peer knowledge and social competencies help us to better understand the feelings, motivations and reactions of our peers. We can develop empathetic and constructive relationships this way. A community becomes truly strong and cohesive when members are able to communicate, cooperate and support each other, while also respecting individual differences. We often hear that children go to school just because of their friends. Shared experiences and tasks, as well as the conscious building of community identity, increase group cohesion, strengthen the sense of belonging, and contribute to the development of a positive class community. This helps children develop in a social environment that enriches their social and emotional skills. If this happens, maybe it will be good to learn together.

Peer knowledge is based on empathy, listening, and understanding from the perspective of others. This skill is able to create harmony in community life, supports the sharing of problems, the joint management of difficulties, and at the same time reduces conflicts and exclusion. It promotes assertive self-expression, cooperation and co-creation. Creation and intimacy – these are the sources of our energy.

Group building

Conscious group building can be one of the most effective tools for teachers. Children love to play, and every game together brings the team closer and closer. During shared group experiences, students experience the power of mutual support, learn to listen, understand others, and respond constructively to conflicts. Thus, the group functions not only as a learning space, but also as a medium that encourages personality development, where trust and empathy provide an emotional basis for effective cooperation.

This area has a huge literature. Perhaps there is one area among the games that we should put special emphasis on. Let's think about the fact that even if we switch from a traditional approach to a cooperative and person-centred approach, children still live in the old, familiar school framework, with old, familiar routines. Cooperation must be taught. Among the games, we diligently look for those that develop thinking according to this other logic. We insert such a game description into this chapter.

Conflict management

There are many things we can do to prevent a conflict from developing and deepening. It is worth preparing in advance for possible conflicts. Relationship-strengthening self-messages, the development of daily routines, the practice of active listening and interpretation at a skill level and many other easily accessible tools can help us in times of trouble. Therefore, it is worth considering conflict management as a curriculum.

Separating the types of conflict helps the teacher not to react with uniform discipline, but to support the understanding and processing of the situation in a targeted manner. Conflicts can come from different sources, and how they are handled depends on what is behind them.

Thomas Gordon[9] recommends six steps to a non-violent resolution of a conflict.

1. Understand the situation and indicate your needs
2. Let's find solutions together
3. We evaluate solutions
4. Choose a solution
5. Let's try it
6. Check if it worked.

9 https://hu.wikipedia.org/wiki/Thomas_Gordon

Daily routines

In the Teacher's Handbook, we discuss in detail the day-to-day solutions that can be used to consciously and indirectly, but definitely continuously develop social skills for years. Starting the day, reflection and self-reflection can be made part of everyday life if we give time for them. Over time, the discussions will provide an increasingly smooth framework for negotiations. Let us not forget that the vehicle of democratic norms is hidden in the daily, repetitive activities. What becomes routine, subroutine, stabilizes. Such are the rules of discussion, which will also be part of the skillset of the students as future employees. Sending correspondence to a meeting is a real managerial task. Many similar life skills can be practiced during the first four years.

Rules and norms

The main difference between a rule and a norm is that rules are usually formally formulated in a specific form, and they can be expected to be enforced in a particular community or organization. These are clear, unambiguous regulations. On the other hand, the norm is rather a set of habits and values that are formed informally, based on a community consensus, and guide behaviour, without necessarily putting them in writing or sanctioning their violation. Most social interactions operate according to norms, and these shape the cultural and moral framework of the community.

It is worth creating the rules together. In doing so, it is important to observe the situations and experiences from which the creation of common rules arises. We formulate the rules together with the students so that they gain real acceptance. When enforcing the rules, instead of punishment, we can use joint responsibility and consistent, empathetic feedback. If someone is not following the rules, it is important to explore the reasons and understand the problems. In the case of small children, we can mainly trust that they will really want to follow the rules we have made together, or if not, we can at least refer to the process!

Collaboration

Like everything, it also needs to be practiced. Fortunately, the school offers opportunities for cooperation every day, in every single lesson, for six to seven hours a day – you just have to notice it and take advantage of it.

Collaboration is a high-level skill that has many components:

- Pure intention and its communication in an understandable manner to the other party.
- Setting clear goals that are accepted and supported by all participants.
- Clear division of labour and responsibility among the members of the group.
- Trust, respect, active listening.
- Non-violent communication and problem-solving.
- Openness, flexibility and adaptability.
- Dealing with emotions and possible frustration
- Commitment to common goals and motivation for personal contribution.
- Continuous evaluation of joint work and continuous feedback for development.

Cognition

Relevance

If we had to determine what is the most important key in the process of cognition, we would have to mention relevance among the first. The basis of the person-centred approach is that the student is open and motivated to learn the things that are important to him. In school (although not necessarily in the first years), it is difficult to make theoretical, abstract, scientific results relevant. When you succeed, it is a great experience for both students and teachers.

ECA brings something new to this. By increasing the variety and free choice, the chances of creating relevant learning increase.

Connect to existing knowledge

When planning a lesson, the teacher always thinks about how the new curriculum relates to what has already been learned in the previous ones. This is the theory. In practice, however, it is difficult to keep track of where a certain child is at the moment. We know where the class is – the teacher keeps track of it mostly. But whether the individual student was sick at the time, or did not pay attention, or listened but could not understand the material – well, we have no insight into this. (That's why we have so many tests written).

In an ECA class, when a student chooses an activity, they will quickly perceive what is missing from

their knowledge until the next step. And once he senses it, we can trust that he will learn it.

Cognitive strategies

These strategies offer conscious ways for students to process and apply the curriculum more effectively. Critical thinking allows them to question information and make decisions on their own, while problem-solving helps them apply what they have learned in practical situations. Creativity encourages the generation of new ideas and flexibility in thinking. Information processing and conceptualization develop their ability to organize and create systems. The development of memory helps to consolidate long-term knowledge, while the conscious application of various learning techniques – such as taking notes, summarizing and repeating – increases the effectiveness of learning. The teaching of cognitive strategies is increasingly supplemented with metacognitive elements, which means that students learn to observe, regulate and consciously control their own thought processes, thus becoming more independent and effective.

In the traditional system, children practice these skills continuously, but they are not expected to be aware of them or point them out in any way. One of the peculiarities of the ECA program is that it creates experiences on the one hand, and provides awareness on the other. Why not make a skill list transparent and understandable for children by slowly dripping it down, even in the first year of school? They will still have plenty of time to practice!

Digital or paper-based problem-solving games, situational tasks, project-based group work, creative brainstorming, memory training or information processing exercises are all tools that develop the application of learning techniques. Modern skill development programs (such as CogniPlus) provide continuous feedback and motivating challenges through adaptive, personalized multimedia tasks. The goal is for students to be able to apply these skills not only in theory, but also in everyday life situations, thus gaining a continuous sense of success.

Creativity

We will discuss creativity separately to give enough attention to this topic. Creativity can be made a curriculum as a stand-alone lesson or in an integrated way.

Creativity Class

In these classes, we develop the following areas in an enjoyable and direct way:

- **Originality and innovation** – recognizing and generating unique ideas that are out of the ordinary, developing alternative ways of thinking.
- **Problem-solving techniques** – creative thinking strategies, brainstorming, association games to solve real or imaginary problems.
- **Risk-taking and experimentation** – trying new solutions, learning from mistakes, developing flexibility, encouraging experimentation.
- **Self-reflection and creative process** – awareness of creative decisions, understanding and developing one's own workflow.
- **Creative communication and collaboration** – expressing and sharing ideas, sensitivity to feedback, incorporating feedback, co-creation.
- **Flexible thinking** – seeking and accepting alternative perspectives and solutions.

One of the tools that can be used to measure creativity is the Torrance test.[10] This test measures different areas of creativity, which are most often examined according to the quantity, variety, originality and elaboration of the ideas generated. The test also measures divergent thinking and problem-solving skills through non-verbal and verbal tasks. We can get an answer to how much a student's thinking is beyond the limits.

In school conditions, with a little attention, creativity development exercises can be integrated into other subjects. We give several examples of this in the Teacher's Handbook, as well as how self-reflective questions can be used to draw attention to the more conscious use of creativity.

10 https://www.scribd.com/document/528183514/Torrence-teszt-korok

Integrated management of subjects

There is great potential in integrating the curriculum and teaching it into subject groups. If we process the separate subjects together in a unified framework, we save time. In this way, unnecessary overlaps can be avoided, as the different elements of knowledge appear in synergy and reinforce each other. There are already a lot of such solutions in the field of science, so it is recommended to start on this path in other subjects as well.

Sustainability

The subject content "Sustainability" within the Environmental Studies subject is intended to create the foundations of environmental awareness and responsible behaviour in the first years of school. The aim of the unit is for students to get acquainted with the relationship between nature and humans, to recognize the importance of protecting the environment, and to develop a positive attitude towards an environmentally conscious lifestyle.

The main topics are:

- Observing nature and living creatures, understanding seasons and weather phenomena, diversity of habitats.
- The interaction between humans and nature, understanding and practicing simple, everyday environmentally conscious actions, establishing routines (e.g. selective waste collection, economization).
- The basics of sustainable resource management, such as simple forms of water and energy saving.
- Protecting the cleanliness and beauty of the local environment, basic forms of avoiding pollution with a playful and emotional approach.
- To illustrate the connection between the community and the environment, the importance of solidarity and responsibility.

These themes aim to develop basic skills and values, while supporting the subsequent development of complex scientific and social knowledge. The unit lays the foundation for a later, deeper study of sustainability and provides students with the opportunity to develop in experiential, active learning situations from an early age.

Special focus of natural science subjects

The focus of sustainability in science subjects is possible in several ways. Firstly, the curriculum can include studies of the functioning of environmental systems, which demonstrate the relationships between humans and nature. Students can thus understand the limitations of natural resources. Field observations and experiments can be involved as experiential learning, during which students can directly experience the aspects of sustainability. We can also work with the method of critical thinking and problem-solving: students can be given creative, practical environmental problems to be solved. Examples and incentive projects related to everyday life (e.g. recycling, energy saving) can help to develop and deepen the sustainability approach in the long term. They will remember these lessons based on experiential learning more throughout their lives than the isolated, though deeper, scientific lessons.

In the first four years of elementary school, basic skills are developed that help children understand the world. These include

- observation, when students learn to perceive natural phenomena accurately and in detail;
- questioning, which helps to express and expand interest and curiosity,
- comparison,
- description, which provides an opportunity to accurately communicate the experiences.

These basics are essential for children to be able to understand and handle more complex scientific concepts and problems, e.g. hypothesis, logical thinking and systems thinking.

The Scissors Program Thought Process

The aim of the Scissors Erasmus+ project was to bring together the scientific curriculum and the development of social competences. The program was also supported by the Tempus Public Foundation.[11] During the project, students became familiar with scientific laws by relying on emotional or social analogies already known from their lives

11 Its leading organization is the Hungarian Rogers Foundation, and its partner institutions are Gedania 1922 in Poland and the University of Jyväskylä in Finland. https://scissors-project.eu/hu/

(or vice versa). To quote an example: Entropy is a physical concept, which in thermodynamics means that if we do not introduce energy or an organizing effect into a closed system, it will move towards a less orderly, simpler, more disintegrated state over time, i.e. its entropy will increase. At the same time, this is a phenomenon that can often be observed in everyday life. If I consider the desk as a closed system and don't invest energy in tidying up, then due to the laws of entropy, the desk will become more and more chaotic. A multitude of similar examples can connect children's own experiences with scientific phenomena, which are easier for them to understand and learn.

An interesting parallel

Primary environmental studies as a learning framework shows a close parallel with the person-centred pedagogical approach. Both are based on observation: first we observe an environment or a child, then we adapt to their needs and opportunities, while also non-violently representing the values that are important to us. In pedagogy and in the garden, wherever possible, let natural processes and spontaneous development prevail, i.e. leave both the garden and the child alone. This approach promotes harmonious coexistence with both nature and the student, supporting experiential and respectful change.

The natural environment and practical activities contribute fundamentally to the calming of the psyche and mental well-being. The garden offers a wide range of activities: you can hide in the shade of a tree, read, climb trees, play catch, the list of possibilities is endless. These activities not only provide physical movement, but also encourage creativity, independence and social play. The permaculture approach supports understanding the functioning and cycles of nature and connecting to it in a sustainable way. In this way, we strengthen the development of the students' positive relationship with nature. Whatever we do, nature as a medium always has a beneficial effect on us; this is a fundamental experience that we can count on in all pedagogical activities and that also develops a positive bond with the school.

Action

Delivering the learning material with activity-based learning paths

The action portion of the ECA Plan responds to the needs of overactive, impulsive learners and also provides an opportunity for learners who have cognitive learning difficulties or progress at a slower pace. While it helps to regulate movement, it supports active participation and the feeling of learning success in a playful, motivating way. The incorporation of exercise is therefore not only for health-promoting purposes, but also offers a complex development opportunity.

All this is realized in such a way that it does not limit, but complements the development opportunities of those who move at a high intellectual level; differentiation allows each learner to participate in practical activities according to their own abilities and needs. The action part thus creates an inclusive, developmental and motivating environment where children from different backgrounds can equally develop.

The list of activities in the action section is endless. In the Teacher's Handbook, we list a lot of examples, but even without this, it can be seen that learning anything can be done through activities. True, it is also the teacher's job to provide the tools, which can cause difficulties. If the learning process is planned for the long term and agreed in advance, the students can also provide the necessary supplies. However, a tinkering class with a good working atmosphere can make up for the extra tiredness of preparation. Over time, we can create a supply room to which students can also have free access.

During the various movement and creative activities, their physical and manual skills develop alongisde their problem-solving skills, independence and ability to cooperate. During the actions, students gain new knowledge, practical techniques and creative solutions. All this also creates an opportunity for students to recognize their own strengths and areas of development.

Projects, thematic days

One solution for incorporating the action part is the already widely known project training. It is one way

to create time to develop emotions and social competencies, as well as a variety of activities that satisfy many children. Project assignments trigger emotional engagement as students actively think and act to achieve the goal.

Its benefits include a holistic learning experience. At the same time, the need for thorough planning can be a challenge and it is more difficult to evaluate, as not only knowledge, but also attitudes and actions play a role.

Since this area also has a huge literature, we only recommend that its inclusion in the routine at least periodically.

Field Exercises, Forest School

Field activities provide students with a direct, experiential connection with the curriculum and nature. They allow for observation and experience at the same time. Working in the field contributes to a deeper understanding of the curriculum and encourages independent learning, as well as a motivating effect by offering students active participation, collaboration and personal experiences. In addition, camps, forest schools, and excursions can be a real field for cooperation and independence.

Involving outsiders

It is also worth involving members of the local community, pedagogical helpers, mentors and health professionals in education. In this way, children can learn from enthusiastic and credible representatives who provide education based on personal experience and professional knowledge. The range of knowledge and development methods is expanding. With this wide-ranging partnership, the action part not only develops the skills and knowledge of children, but also strengthens the cohesive power of the community and the system of supporting learning.

Content aspects of the subjects

If we look at the subjects of a primary school student, we can find all three ECA aspects: communication, writing, reading, stories, counting, singing, drawing, tinkering, movement, dilemmas, information technology and environmental studies.

Still, the ECA curriculum can add to this package: more movement, more being in the natural environment, choices, creativity, and caring for yourself, your peers, and sustainability. In addition, the focus is also moved elsewhere:

- The learning focus: the subjects focus on solving complex, real-life tasks
- The emphasis of teaching methods shifts from frontal to cooperation and independence
- The importance of self-esteem and self-reflection increases instead of or in addition to tests
- Instead of regular lessons, we organize learning in larger learning blocks
- Motivation does not come from grades, but from student interest.

In the Teacher's Handbook, we provide many examples of ECA processing of National Curriculum topics. Here is a list of how we can process content elements – any cognitive content – with an ECA approach. For each subject, we have prepared many examples that include cognitive content, a related emotional question, and a simple activity idea. Of course, due to the model's characteristics, this is a simplified approach, but our goal is to make it as easy and quick as possible for teachers to incorporate this structure into their education system.

The ECA is able to adapt to the content of the traditional curriculum. However, we need to formulate our priorities, because although we can achieve deeper knowledge with the ECA trinity, it will not take the same amount of time.

We lose time trying to

- care more about children than with what they have to learn. The traditional system responds to curricular needs, while ECA is based on the needs of children.
- have children bring in questions. Most of the topics raised by the children are obviously related to National Curriculum content. However, questions may also arise that are not, or are not material for other grades.

How to deal with this problem?

- We integrate the content. Let's regroup the things to learn into a different bunch, maybe

then we can tick off more knowledge in one ECA session.

- Tell the children what you need to condense into an ECA lesson. They will help you figure out how to do this.
- Let's take note of the holistic development of children and taking into account age-specific characteristics are more important than expanding the content.

4.
Methodology

Teacher as facilitator

We have already talked about the transformation of teachers' roles, but now we are examining this issue from the point of view of developmental assessment, especially the evaluation of young children. In early childhood, the personal significance of the teacher is enormous, as it is a peculiarity of children at their age that they look up to them and want to conform to them. This decisive relationship helps the students' sense of security and lays the foundation for the first assessment experiences. However, the process of developmental assessment requires conscious work on the part of the teacher. He is the one who guides the students until they gradually learn to take responsibility for their own learning. In this process, the teacher transforms into a facilitator and mentor who evaluates and supports, guides and encourages, and provides an opportunity for self-reflection and self-evaluation. This process requires years of conscious and careful pedagogical work, in which the teacher constantly adapts to the changing needs and developmental stages of the children, but always keeping in mind the goal: to give his students the freedom of self-evaluation and self-reflection.

We are different

No one disputes that we are different. At the same time, the world of school still often works as if students are listening, feeling, thinking and learning in a similar way. The current system relies far less on human differences than it could or would be worthwhile. With ECA, we are trying to move forward in this.

Maslow's pyramid[12]

Not only are we different, but even our needs change fom time to time. Abraham Maslow's hierarchy of needs theory describes a system of basic human needs that builds on each other, ranging from survival (food, security) through physiological needs (food, sleep, etc.) to development (self-realization):

- Security
- Social needs
- Self-esteem, recognition
- Cognitive needs
- Aesthetic needs
- Self-realization

According to the theory, we can only go up in a row. Therefore, recognizing the different needs of students and taking into account their daily changes in education is key to promoting effective learning.

Multiple Intelligences[13]

According to Howard Gardner's theory of multiple intelligences, intelligence is not a single unified ability, but we now distinguish ten different, independent intelligences:

1. **Linguistic – verbal:** use of words, language, writing, reading.
2. **Logical-mathematical:** systematization, numbers, abstract thinking.
3. **Spatial:** interpretation of images, forms, spatial relations.
4. **Musical:** understanding rhythm, sounds, melodies.
5. **Physical-kinesthetic:** movement, physical skills (e.g. sports, dance).
6. **Social (interpersonal):** understanding the feelings, intentions and motivations of others, managing social relationships.
7. **Personal (intrapersonal):** knowledge of one's own feelings, motivations, abilities.

12 https://hu.wikipedia.org/wiki/Abraham_Maslow
13 https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Theory_of_multiple_intelligences

8. **Natural:** sensitivity to nature, the environment, living creatures.
9. **Practical:** taking care of everyday things.
10. **Existential:** the great questions of existence.

It is very important that teachers not only accept the differences between students, but also consciously observe and actively use them in everyday pedagogical work. The multiple-intelligence approach helps with this: it makes children more sensitive to the fact that children are connected to the world in different ways, strong in different ways, motivated in different ways, and reach understanding in different ways.

Love languages[14]

Surely everyone knows the five love languages. It's just about their differences. According to Gary Chapman, love language is the way a person expresses and experiences love. And the five love languages are as follows:

- Words of appreciation
- Quality Time
- Gifts
- Favors
- Physical touch

If the teacher gets to know and uses these languages well with the children, his benevolence and care will be transferred to them more easily. This knowledge will be a great help during evaluation and feedback.

Learning management

Individual, pair and small group work

Pair and small group work is already a well-known and a widely used form of learning in traditional school practice, but their role in the ECA curriculum is increasing. Just for the sake of completeness, let's start the list of options with this.

These working methods are the most important tools for developing collaborative skills, as they promote active student participation, communication and joint problem-solving. They provide opportunities for students to share ideas, discuss views and learn from each other, thereby also supporting the development of social competences and emotional intelligence.

Agile methodology[15]

In order to incorporate the latest trends into everyday life, it is also worth being aware of the form of work that is now called agile.

The essence of the agile approach is that we proceed in smaller steps, constantly ask for feedback, and flexibly adjust the next steps based on experience – we do not follow a rigid, pre-closed plan. This requires skills on the part of the teacher, such as flexibility, openness to experimentation, cooperative teamwork (with children and colleagues), good questioning techniques and regular, developmental feedback.

For example, with children aged 6-12, this can look like the teacher working in "mini-projects": together with the children, they set a short goal (e.g. designing a poster, staging a scene, conducting an experiment), work on it in a 1-2 hour "sprint", at the end they see together what went well and what they would like to change next, and then plan the next round based on these. In this way, children experience that we learn from mistakes, that we can try quickly on a small scale, and that they are also active shapers of the learning process, not just passive participants.

Differentiation

In an optimal case, differentiated assignment is a discussion between the teacher and the individual student, which is based on the student's commitment in order to learn a given topic in the most suitable way for him/her. In this process, the student's ideas in terms of learning methods are preferred. With regard to content, it is the teacher's task to represent the requirements of the National Core Curriculum. It represents it, but does not force it on the student. It is important that all members of the class are aware of the expectations of the National Curriculum, but it is not the teacher's job to extort this from the students. The grades reflect the percentage of the NCC content acquired, if grading is carried out, while in the written assessment it is also possible to explain individual differences in detail.

14 https://hu.wikipedia.org/wiki/Az_%C3%B6t_szeretetnyelv
15 https://promanconsulting.hu/mi-az-agilis-modszertan-legelterjedtebb-agilis-modszertanok/

Interest-tracking, flexible design

The aim of the ECA program is to enable teachers to routinely apply many of the following list of learning management principles of the ECA methodology for inclusion and support:

- tries to get to know his students, their individual traits,
- listens to students' feedback and questions, shapes the learning content based on these,
- uses personalized tasks or optional topics,
- is open to unexpected situations,
- adapts to the different pace and learning style of the students,
- apply cooperative forms of learning,
- supports students' independence and responsibility in shaping their learning path,
- monitors and supports the individual curiosity and interest of learners;
- provides a personalized learning experience.

Teaching aids, equipment requirements

Digital and analogue teaching aids

In the 21st century, the most important question is the accurate knowledge and widespread use of these two tools. The following table summarizes the main characteristics of the pedagogical functions of digital and analogue teaching aids, thus helping the conscious selection and application of appropriate solutions in education.

Pedagogical function	Analogue Devices	Digital Devices
Availability and access	Easily accessible paper-based textbooks, workbooks, wall maps	Varies depending on internet access and device
Interactivity	Limited in size, mainly suitable for passive reception	High, with interactive tasks and multimedia elements
Learning management	Teacher-led, unified progress	Individual pace, on specific routes
Knowledge Measurement and Feedback	Manual assessment, based on teacher observation	Automated tests, instant feedback
Motivation and involvement	Touching and reading physical materials	Playful, diverse digital content, interaction
Upgradability and extensibility	Less flexible, new edition required	Quick updates, expansions, with content available online
Technical conditions	Does not require technology	Requires a suitable device and internet connection
Pedagogical applicability	Suitable for illustration with traditional methods	Supports modern, digital pedagogy and adaptive learning

The choice is not easy. When trying to decide, we can place the aspect of support of individual and group learning to the front of the row.

From this point of view, the advantage of digital learning tools is that students can progress at their own pace, repeat and receive immediate feedback on tasks, which increases their motivation and helps them learn more consciously. Collaboration can also be effective in group learning, as digital platforms allow for online communication, collaborative editing and interactive task solving, making it easier for students to share ideas and learn from each other. These opportunities allow for flexibility, creativity, and personalized learning paths. This also increases the independence of the students.

The advantage of traditional teaching aids is that they provide access to basic knowledge in a simple, tangible form, and it is easier to practice reading and writing. With these learning tools, students can work in a systematic, easy-to-follow framework, which is especially important during early skill development. In group learning, shared workbooks, paper-based games or tangible aids facilitate the acquisition of shared experience, while they are easier to handle and less burdensome for teachers in terms of technical conditions. They strengthen manual skills, tactile learning, and also contribute to the focus of children's attention. We don't even need to mention how deeply the personal experience touches us.

Thus, we see that analogue tools support the development of manual skills and are easily accessible to everyone in the combined use of learning tools, while digital tools can make the learning process more interactive and personalized. In addition to safe, easy-to-follow traditional tools, a digital interactive task bank or various educational platforms make learning more experiential. Digitalization also makes the teacher's job significantly easier in providing different learning styles.

Below are some of the pages where you can get a comprehensive picture of the digital tools and methods that support education (currently available), including interactive learning materials, learning management systems and technological tools.

1. Pixelwings.hu: a compilation of the tools and methods of digital education (e.g. LMS systems, webinars, interactive content, gamification, VR/AR education), and they are described in detail: https://pixelwings.hu/digitalis-oktatas-eszkozok-es-modszerek/
2. Oktatás.hu: a knowledge base on the use of IT tools in the classroom, especially on SDT learning materials and digital learning tools: https://ofi.oh.gov.hu/tudastar/informatikai-eszkozok-090617
3. Microsoft Education Digital Learning Tools page, where Microsoft learning tools are showcased: https://www.microsoft.com/hu-hu/education/learning-tools

There are also plenty of analogue devices in the catalogue. As an example:

- Balázs Diák Webshop: https://webshop.balazs-diak.hu/black-november
- Mozaik Publisher: https://www.mozaik.info.hu/Homepage/Mozaportal/index.php
- **Recommended textbook families and publications**

  1. **KOMP competency-based program package**
     - The Technical Publishing House "KOMP textbooks (grades 1-2-3)": muszakikiado.hu

  2. **Environmental Studies – "Secrets of Our Environment" series**
     - Mozaik Publishing House's "Secrets of Our Environment" textbook family is available from 1st grade: Mozaik
     - KELLO Online Bookstore
     - The kreativjatek.hu series can be used well if we build on the experiences, observations and activities of the students.

  3. **Digital + ICT-supported learning materials**
     - OFI primary school curricula with digital content: Oktatási Hivatal

5.
Learning Activities

Emotion

Topics that develop emotional intelligence are consciously developed in all educational systems. This is the job of every teacher and the focus of most of them at the same time – it comes with a teaching career. In the ECA program, the importance of this area increases – it becomes one of the main goals.

How do children experience the activities that can be classified in this category? As expected: in different ways. Some people like it, some don't, some get bored, and some have a good time... These practices create an opportunity to become aware of and analyse their own thoughts, feelings, and behaviours, and help them to connect more deeply with themselves, recognize their strengths and areas of development, and better understand their emotional and cognitive processes. Students actively participate in self-reflection, for example by keeping journals, answering questions, or during group discussions. They know that they promote a more complex understanding of themselves and their personal development. Yet building this consciousness is a task that some people like and others don't.

Cognition

Cognitive tasks develop students' active thinking and problem-solving skills. These tasks require interpretation, analysis, comparison, inference, and creative thinking – thus supporting deeper processing of information and long-term acquisition. From the point of view of ECA, students perform the same activities as their peers in traditional classes: they ask questions, create models, create projects, or solve problems, all of which strengthen critical thinking and the ability to apply what they have learned. Challenging but achievable tasks equally increase students' interest and engagement. Teachers handle different levels of thinking in the same way, as from simple questions to complex problems, the ability to think can be increased by combining low and high level cognitive tasks.

So how do ECA students differ from the activities side? Let's see a summary list:

- **They are not only recipients of information,** but also active participants in the learning process: they give and reject topics, bring independent ideas for processing, or set the time they devote to activities.
- **In the optimal case,** the tasks are personalized, born according to individual goals and adapted to individual abilities, so learning will be more effective.
- **Students become aware of their own thought processes.** This metacognition has a personality development effect.
- **Group work, discussions, cooperative tasks** continuously encourage cognitive activity and the understanding of multiple perspectives.
- **Relevant, positive, textual feedback helps** students to self-assess and correct mistakes.

Action

Let's dwell on the Action page for a while. Here are what's new.

Movement

We know that in early childhood, movement supports not only physical, but also complex developmental processes. On a physical level, movement helps to strengthen muscles and bones, as well as to develop coordination and balance. At the level of mental and cognitive development, it positively influences the development of the brain and fine and large motor skills, and also improves attention and learning abilities. It even has a great impact on emotional and social development, as children learn the importance of following the rules, regulating their

emotions and practicing coping in cooperative and competitive situations while moving and playing.

Regular exercise contributes in a complex way to maintaining a healthy weight, strengthening the cardiovascular system, and preventing diseases. The experience of playful movement increases the desire to learn and also develops many basic life skills: independence, self-confidence, perseverance, problem-solving skills and risk management.

So don't keep small children in the bench for 5-6 hours a day – let them come and go freely and develop routines that can keep discipline even in larger groups of 20-25 people.

Creative creation

When the school becomes a field for the creative action, we take a big step towards creating a learning community with a good atmosphere. There are several determining elements of this from the point of view of their student activity.

- **Supporting the student's self-expression:** displaying their own ideas, experiences and emotions in images, objects, movements, texts.
- **Experimentation and discovery:** free, playful experimentation of materials, tools, techniques, mistakes as an opportunity to learn.
- **Problem-solving and planning:** children come up with solutions themselves, plan and then modify the steps of the task-solving process.
- **Alternation of individual and cooperative work:** own creation and joint projects, individual joint installations, group work.
- **Emotional and ecological connection:** themes related to nature, the environment, one's own experiences, the use of recycled materials.
- **Reflective closure:** discussion, mini-exhibition, self-reflection questions about creation and the process, not only about the "beautiful end result".

Extracurricular Activities

The following is a summary of the benefits of learning outside the school premises. The purpose of the regular time spent at outdoor locations is to make students become open to the diverse learning opportunities of their environment and to absorb new information through experiences. What do these extracurricular activities mean?

- **Learning in the everyday environment:** during sightseeing and city walks, children will experience that the city, historical sites, streets and buildings are also valuable learning resources.
- **Interactive museum activities:** under the guidance of museum educators, museums and galleries become an experiential, active learning field.
- **Observation and networking:** as students walk around the city, they observe the details of the environment and connect new knowledge with their previous knowledge.
- **Technology support:** the teacher, as a living encyclopaedia, answers questions quickly with the help of the phone in his pocket, supporting the immediate expansion of knowledge.
- **Flexibility and problem-solving:** during situations outside of school, such as travelling, students learn to adapt and find creative solutions, for example, if they need to develop an alternative mode of transport for a peer.
- **Experience-based learning:** shared experiences result in emotional involvement and thus more lasting knowledge.
- **Everything and everyone can be a teacher:** children understand that they can learn anywhere and anytime, even a city street, a museum object or the experience of a peer can be a source of learning.

If students get used to the idea that everything and everyone can be a source of learning, as Carl Rogers claims, we will take a big step towards lifelong learning.

In both our Curriculum and the Teacher's Handbook, we have illustrated ECA learning organization with a lot of practical examples. Let us now summarize the most important organizational principles, practical implementation steps and student activities.

Principles of individual learning organization:

- Learning is organized based on personal needs, abilities, and interests.
- Education is personalized, supports independent learning and the autonomy of students.
- In addition to emotional intelligence and social competences, it promotes multidimensional development.
- It builds on an experiential learning process.

The practice of differentiated learning organization:

- Adapting to the different learning paces, emotional states and styles of students.
- Use a variety of learning methods.
- Flexible learning environment.
- Combining digital technologies and traditional knowledge carriers.
- Strengthening the facilitator role of the teacher.

Moments of the student activity:

- The children work according to individual goals.
- Strengthening students' emotional attachment to the curriculum.
- The focus is on the activity and responsibility of the students.
- Observation, questioning, comparison and description in the acquisition of knowledge lay the foundations for scientific thinking.
- Incorporating close-to-nature experiences and environmentally conscious action.

6.
Timeframe and time planning

School-level time management

When managing the school time frame, it is important to take into account that a lot of time is already given for different programs in the school routine. Such as holidays (historical holidays, school Christmas, etc.), camps at the beginning or end of the year, and some schools already have built-in projects or thematic days. If these are not yet integrated into the operation, they must be integrated, or if they are already present, the task is to involve the students in the design. Study groups and faculties are also a good terrain.

Flexible schedule

Consider that the only overall school requirement of the ECA program is to optimally think in larger teaching units, in 90-minute blocks, instead of 45-minute lessons, so that the three ECA aspects can be effectively represented within a teaching unit. In the beginning, an even, balanced (e.g. 30-30-30 minutes) schedule is recommended as a transitional principle when planning lessons until teachers get used to this triple unity. This division supports the effective implementation of new pedagogical goals by optimizing the time factor.

Another important aspect of flexible time management is taking into account the different pace of student work. In order for each child to be able to work at their own pace, pedagogical tools are needed, such as creating agreements about what happens to students who are progressing exceptionally fast or slow. It is important to think about, and in some cases regulate, what a student can do if he finishes the task first, and what options he has if he cannot finish it in time. Through a developmental attitude and the involvement of children's ideas, oral, individual solutions can be created, which can even be part of the Individual Learning Contract.

The flexibility of the ECA does not mean a lack of structure. The following minimum rules ensure the regularity and effectiveness of the programme:

1. **Daily reflection routine:** at the end of each school day, there is an opportunity for self-reflection and sharing experiences.
2. **Minimum 1 ECA block per week:** in 90-minute units (E-C-A cycle), instead of 45-minute lessons.
3. **Project time in 4-6 week cycles:** at least 1 thematic project per semester (e.g. gardening, sustainability week), with inter-subject integration.

So we can see that although the routine needs to be reconsidered, it is not an unfeasible or huge change that requires a huge transformation to introduce the ECA idea. On the time front, we don't pay a big price.

7.
Review

ECA Assessment Principles

We reviewed that ECA is a complex system that makes certain changes in terms of both development requirements and content. To do this, we will also have to create a separate evaluation system.

The ECA Assessment Principles focus on the holistic and active support of learner development. The purpose of the assessment is to quantify the results, as well as to promote the self-reflection and self-development of the students.

ECA's evaluation principles in points:

- **Primacy of self-assessment** – learners are actively involved in the assessment of their own learning processes, becoming aware of their strengths and areas for improvement.
- **Constructive feedback is a priority** – the purpose of feedback is to provide support, motivation and directions for development, not to hold mistakes accountable.
- **Regular incorporation of feedback** – learners learn to process and apply the feedback they receive in their learning strategies. Developing a reflective evaluation culture.
- **Practicing feedback** – providing a continuous, repetitive opportunity to give and receive feedback. Involving peers in the evaluation process.
- **Flexibility and individualisation** – adapting assessment forms and aspects to the individual needs and pace of development of the students, as well as their emotional and cognitive state.

Expected outcome of the evaluation

We need to look at one more important question, which perhaps we could have started with: how can we determine the results of our work? Donald Kickpatrick recommends four aspects to examine:

1. **Satisfaction** (student and teacher) (result of self-reflective work)
2. **The degree of acquisition of cognitive content** (tests, surveys, exams are used for this)
3. **The direction and extent of the change in behaviour** (we can use feedback for this)
4. **Tangible changes in everyday life** (more and better relationships, academic results, changes in the number of well-resolved conflicts, etc. A thousand small details that we usually do not even notice, do not become aware of, and do not connect in any way to our learning processes.)

We can see that this assessment portfolio examines the outcome of learning in a wider spectrum than the traditional system. This is natural, as the list of content and development requirements has also been expanded.

Assessment features

Let's review the functions of evaluation and see how each one can be integrated into the ECA approach.

- In order to create a good individual learning plan, it is essential to carry out a diagnostic assessment, i.e. to explore the student's prior knowledge, abilities and needs before the learning process.
- We have already talked about developmental (formative) evaluation, this is feedback.
- The motivational function has also been mentioned – this is the confirmation of (small) successes.
- The information function, the grades, provide information about the progress made.
- The purpose of the summative function is to qualify.

Of these functions used in traditional schools, all of them, with the exception of certification, are very important in person-centred pedagogy as well, and the use of all of them is also expected in the ECA approach. Obviously, we will not qualify personality development or social competencies, but the summative grades of the subjects are part of school compliance. So what is the difference between an ECA process and a traditional lesson in terms of assessment?

Grade in addition to and instead of developmental assessment

A grade is a formal assessment tool that indicates the final assessment of a given learning phase or achievement and is primarily used as information for the outside world, such as parents and school management. It can also act as a motivational tool, but it does not provide enough feedback on learners' progress or development opportunities on its own. In contrast, developmental assessment provides students with continuous, detailed and constructive feedback throughout the learning process, encouraging self-reflection and personalized development.

It is effective when applied alongside the grade, so that students receive not only a summary assessment, but also continuous feedback on the direction and pace at which they are progressing. In some situations, it is useful to use developmental assessment rather than grades, especially in developmental activities, because it helps to avoid the stress and anxiety of exclusive evaluation. Developmental assessment supports a deeper understanding of the children's learning process, increases their motivation and also provides an opportunity for teachers to react flexibly to developmental needs and improvements. Thus, the two forms of assessment can complement each other well in educational practice.

Documentation

In the ECA system, both oral and written documentation covers in detail the emotional, cognitive and action dimensions of the students in order to provide a complete picture of the development of each student. Assessment is based on feedback from multiple perspectives and from multiple sides, including the student's self-assessment, teacher observations, and peer feedback. This provides complexity and depth. The regularity and frequency of feedback helps the continuous development of students, as all feedback, whether positive or corrective, is a source of valuable information from which one can learn. As Rogers says, facts are my friends.

Grade breakdown and a transitional model

In grades 1 and 2, the ECA assessment is mainly based on narrative feedback and simple scales, e.g. "You listened well to your peers today", "You talked about your work much more than before". At this stage, the teacher and the student form a common language about development.

In grades 3 and 4, we can gradually introduce elements of self-assessment and peer assessment, e.g. "What did you learn from your peers today?", "How do you think your group has improved?", while we also include NCC assessments and school expectations (tests, grades).

This transitional model gives students the opportunity to become familiar with the language of the traditional system, while at the same time becoming familiar with the development-oriented, trust-based assessment culture of ECA. The manual contains specific samples: emotional competence development scale, minimum portfolio content, daily reflection diary, project products, peer feedback.

Criteria

In the ECA process, the selection of assessment criteria is made in collaboration with students. The aspects can be predetermined, but they can also be modified during the learning process or even afterwards. In the case of the preliminary creation of common criteria, students have a better understanding of the qualitative aspects, thus they can strive more consciously to achieve the set goals and can be more motivated to actively participate in the learning process. The modifications provide an opportunity for flexibility, adaptation to individual development paths, and the incorporation of students' self-reflection. Unconventional aspects may also come forth, such as the degree of creativity, the quality of group work or the complexity of the given task, which can be interpreted and monitored during the joint discussion with the students.

Requirements and minimum performance

The requirements define the competences, knowledge and skills that learners must achieve in order to complete a given unit of curriculum or subject level in order to ensure transparency, measurability and comparability (as long as they are considered important). Minimum performance is a reference point that includes the most basic criteria for effectiveness. In the first three years, this relationship takes due account of the individual development path, abilities and circumstances of the students even in the traditional system. Thus, we can proceed in the usual way in the ECA system. Perhaps the difference is in communication. We need to devote more individual attention and more time to this issue in general.

By the end of Year 4, the following will be added to the commonly used output profile:

- **Emotional awareness:** recognizes and names one's own emotions, and connects with one's peers with empathy.
- **Cooperation:** resolves conflicts, works effectively in a group.
- **Autonomy:** chooses one's own task, plans one's steps, often works persistently and independently.
- **Environmental awareness:** consciously saves resources.
- **Motivation:** learns with inner joy, reflects on his own development, is curious about new things.

Cognitive minimum (subject to NCC)

The cognitive minimum means the acquisition of the basic knowledge and competencies prescribed by the National Curriculum, which are essential for continuing in upper school and include age-specific expectations. In the ECA curriculum, these requirements remain unchanged, but they are enriched with E-C-A logic: cognitive content is always coupled with emotional attunement and action, ensuring lasting fixation and a relevant experience.

Minimum performance of sustainability

The minimum of ECA sustainability is participation in practical, observable actions based on development requirements. The documentation is based on the project product (photo + description) in the portfolio, reflection drawings and facilitator feedback.

Grades 1–2

- Independently, they put paper and plastic into the appropriate selective bin.
- They reflect on sustainability aspects (water reduction, waste collection).
- They participate in group actions.
- In their own words, they articulate why it is important to take care of the animals and plants that live with us.

End of grades 3-4

- They formulate two concrete actions with which they themselves protect the environment. This can be seen.
- They had at least one community initiative on the subject during the year.
- They prepare their own sustainability plan.

Social-emotional minimum

The social-emotional minimum refers to the observable signs of emotional intelligence and social skills. Documentation is done with narrative feedback ("Today you understood your partner's feelings well") and simple scales.

In grades 1 and 2:

- In a safe environment, they recognize their own basic emotions and are able to name them.
- With help (when warned), they can listen to their partner ("Now we are listening to you").
- They are able to work in a group ("I'm waiting for my turn").

Grades 3-4:

- They are able to name their own emotions and the triggers in simple words.
- They can briefly recall what they heard from their partner.
- They are able to express empathy ("I ask him what's wrong").
- They are able to articulate if something is bothering them and make suggestions for improving the situation.
- They are able to discuss a minor conflict with their partner peacefully, without the intervention of the teacher.

Sale minimum

The action focuses on minimum action skills, which is also the basis of the documentation.

In grades 1 and 2:

- They choose their own assignment from the offered ones and works with it, if necessary, with a teacher's warning.
- They initiate, make proposals.
- They tell you what they would change next.
- There are products to show in their portfolio.

In grades 3-4:

- They choose their own assignment from the offered ones and works with it without warning from the teacher.
- They plan the steps of a simple task and follow the plan largely independently.
- They continue the task even after an unsuccessful attempt.
- In group work, they take responsibility for the preparation of their own part.
- They can also find their place in the class within flexible frameworks.

8.
Relationship with parents

Cooperation with families in today's educational environment is a sensitive issue, because the traditional school system often kept a great distance from parents in order to avoid questioning pedagogical autonomy or professional decisions, or conflicts. This attitude is understandable, as parents often represent their own child's interests in a biased way, the other party is actually "deaf", and sometimes it is difficult for them to accept that the school does not always make decisions that meet their personal expectations. Seclusion can be a protection against arguments, but in the long run it hinders the development of trust, a safe atmosphere and open communication between the school and the family.

Build trust

Building trust with parents is of paramount importance. Not only because according to the humanistic approach, our attention must extend to all participants, but also because they are the closest supporters of the students. Open communication, collaboration, and sharing common goals help strengthen this relationship of trust, which is the foundation for children's successful learning experience and acceptance of change in the school community.

Common values and goals

The formulation and acceptance of common values between parents and the school is essential for successful cooperation. When both parties strive in the same direction for the development, emotional and social well-being, and academic progress of the children, it strengthens trust and the possibility of success. So let's be open about what we want, what our goals are, and why. We emphasize the values along which we intend to achieve these goals. Accept that not everyone agrees with you. Let's hope that there will be enough people who can identify with our curriculum with the changed proportions! In this work, the school management must show the way to class teachers and teachers.

Clarifying boundaries and roles

There are some important questions worth asking in the parent-school cooperation: what are the responsibilities and tasks of the school and the parents? How can proper communication and cooperation be ensured between the two parties? To what extent and in what way can parents be involved in school life and decision-making? Answering these questions will help to establish a clear framework that supports the child's development and the strengthening of the school community. It is good to think about all this together with the parents. With the help of organizational development tools, large groups and smaller units can be successfully involved in the discussion and reconciliation.

Consider that parents may feel that the responsibility of education is taken out of their hands during changes in the school. The emphasis on the humanistic approach helps in this: we respect the role and right of parents in shaping their children's lives, and we consider it the task of the school to support the harmonious development of the child with gentle, positive means. This approach ensures that the parenting process is collaborative and value-centred, strengthening the parent-school partnership for the child's emotional and social development.

Communication channels, cooperation frameworks

During the change, it matters a lot if we develop clear, regulated communication channels and cooperation frameworks in advance. These ensure that parents and teachers alike are aware of when and where they can have their say and can share their opinions in a regulated setting. At first, management and teachers may feel this openness is dangerous, and it should be expected that until both parties learn the new situation, conflicts may multiply. At the same time, if they overcome the first difficulties, a more humane and harmonious school community can be formed.

9.
Local characteristics, adaptation

ECA-generated changes

Let's take a brief look at the changes brought about by the ECA approach.

1. **Objectives → The development of emotional intelligence, self-awareness, social competence and intrinsic motivation will be a central goal.**
   The first step of adaptation is the birth of the will to incorporate the ECA principles into the setting of pedagogical goals and operation. This initial step is the conscious decision to focus on the development of emotional intelligence (EQ), self-awareness, social competence and intrinsic motivation. This step in the pedagogical process creates the framework in which the teacher will be able to create learning experiences that balance emotional, cognitive and active learning skills. At the same time, another decision is to make other ECA priority areas, creativity and sustainability.

2. **Developmental requirements → In addition to cognitive, social-emotional competencies are given primary importance.**
   The developmental requirements must be fundamentally changed in order to ensure that the emphasis is not only on the development of cognitive skills, but that emotional and social competencies are given equal weight in all aspects. This change allows students to not only expand their knowledge, but also develop their emotional intelligence and social skills. Thus, the pedagogical process becomes a holistic approach that supports the healthy self-knowledge, ability to cooperate, and acquisition of knowledge by students.

3. **Changes in subject content**
   In the case of changes in subject content, two changes must be applied.
   One of the content changes is to have fewer expectations in terms of knowledge, while placing more emphasis on behavioural, cooperative and self-reflection skills. This social-emotional learning is interwoven with all subjects, all of which we need to provide time for.
   The essence of the other content change is that we need to incorporate more experience-based, practical learning content and actions into school time. Thus, learning at school becomes an experiential and meaningful activity for students.
   The extent to which a teacher is empowered to make such decisions is selected by their school. It is possible to imagine a set-up where these content decisions already push the boundaries or even cross them. In this case, our suggestion is a bargain: we should start on the road as much and to the extent that it is possible. The idea of "bargaining" perfectly reflects the flexibility of the facilitator – the teacher has room for manoeuvre without having to confront the rules of the school. So this is one of the key competencies of the facilitator.

4. **Learning organization, methodology**
   Of course, the methodology must also change, from two aspects.
   On the one hand, it is a big change that the role of the teacher is transformed into a facilitator who supports the active participation of the students. Cooperative techniques, movement and creative tasks and differentiation come forth so that each student can develop according to their individual needs.

On the other hand, children's interests must play a central role in the learning process. The methodology incorporates elements that help to adapt to the individual interests and pace of development of the students.

5. **Learning Activities**

We also need to make two changes in student activities.

Active participation, group work, self-assessment and experiential actions should become mandatory core elements, supporting learners' ownership and the development of their cooperation skills. This approach strengthens personal motivation and deeper, more lasting mastery of learning.

At the same time, the continuous consideration of individual pace, interest and emotional state is of paramount importance to ensure a personalized and effective learning experience. Again, this leads to more motivated learning and deeper fixation.

6. **Number of Hours / Time Frames**

A big change in terms of the number of hours and time frames is that a more flexible system is needed that ensures the problem-free integration of the time required for actions into the learning process.

7. **Assessment and evaluation → Developmental assessment; self-assessment, peer assessment, scales, portfolio, reflective diary.**

Traditional school assessment is primarily dominated by the final, qualifying assessment, in the course of which the students' knowledge is assessed and graded mainly through tests and oral answers. The emphasis is on the verification of factual knowledge and summary examinations. In the ECA program, this role is taken over by formative, developmental assessment, which focuses on self-evaluation, peer evaluation, scales, portfolio, and reflective diary.

If we have to use these two approaches at the same time, following the spirit of the school, we recommend that we put this problem in front of the students and discuss it. It is not an easy task, but this solution creates a clear situation. The students experience the teacher's trust and can also see whether they meet the expectations of the whole school. The democratic discussion of the dual evaluation system (ECA + school) is itself EQ development, autonomy building, and serves as a model. It is precisely this kind of "meta-learning" that makes ECA unique.

10.
Teacher's role and competencies

Only a teacher who is prepared in spirit can carry out the above. Let's see how.

Facilitator presence

In the spirit of ECA, the teacher constantly supports, directs and encourages the independent work of the students. He listens carefully to the children's opinions and questions, and shapes learning situations by reflecting on them. He notices when someone is stuck or has motivational problems and provides personalized help. He promotes cooperation and communication between students, encourages brainstorming and joint problem-solving, preferably in a way that students remain active participants in the learning process. The facilitator is gently directing, which gives security, develops autonomy and leaves freedom for creative and independent thinking. This presence allows students to boldly experiment, make mistakes, and learn from those mistakes. The facilitator provides a framework for the work – it ensures that the group as a whole can function in such a way that individuals may be doing completely different jobs. Let's see all this in a table:

Features	Teacher	Facilitator
Teacher's role	Knowledge transfer, information transfer	Supporting the learning process, helping with questions and feedback
Central task	Transfer of expertise, curriculum organization	Supporting students' activity, self-reflection and community building
Learner role	Passive receivers, Live data storage,	Active participants, independent thinkers
Presence	Control the learning process	Facilitates, supports, directs (according to what the students need at any given time)
Methods	Lesson-centred presentation, Q&A, one-way information communication	Questions, discussions, joint problem solving, group work, two-way communication
Purpose	Knowledge transfer and verification	Developing learning-related competences
Attitude	Authoritarian, knowledge-forming role, guiding	Equality, partnership, encouragement, openness to dialogue
Opportunity for development	Expansion of the knowledge base, methodological development	Facilitation techniques, creating a working environment, providing resources
Conflict management	The teacher's responsibility, regulates, possibly punishes, rewards	It is in the hands of the teacher or the students, the teacher is a consultant or mediator
Decision Making	It is mainly the teacher who makes decisions in the affairs of the class, or perhaps listens to the students	The teacher supports joint decision-making, often delegates, and listens to the students by all means

Features	Teacher	Facilitator
Student activity	Unified, everyone does the same thing	Roles adapted to individual abilities, optional activities
Learning environment	Structured, regulated	Flexible, adapted to the current needs of students
Evaluation, feedback	Formal, summative, informative and levelling focus	Continuous, development-focused
Student autonomy	Limited, dominated by teacher control	The teacher supports independent learning and encourages initiative

The Teacher's Leadership Role

In the ECA system, the teacher has changed from teacher to facilitator on the one hand, and on the other hand, he or she moves from a role at the top of the hierarchy to a partnership. It is not an easy nor an impossible task: it contains challenges, but it helps a lot in managing the group.

There are two things to deal with in the initial phase:

1. I'm here in my class, everyone is working, but what am I supposed to do? Is it okay that I don't teach?
2. I constantly work with children who do not work, have difficulty learning or are excited, so that the quieter ones can do their job. Is this okay? Don't the well-functioning ones have the same right and need me?

Unfortunately, teachers are not prepared at the university for what they already know and teach very well in management science: situational leadership.

Situational Leadership[16]

This is a leadership model based on flexibility, according to which the effective functioning of the leader depends on the situation, the level of autonomy of the group members and the nature of the task. Depending on the degree of guidance and support, the leader chooses the style that best suits the challenges of the situation and the needs of the group.

They teacher may be a:

- **Controlling leader:** if the student has little experience, struggles with learning problems, lacks self-confidence, or is still getting acquainted with the work process and needs strong guidance, precise instructions, detailed regulation, and close control to complete the task.
- **Coach leader:** if the student already has some knowledge and skills, but still needs support and encouragement in making independent decisions, he is in a transitional phase. In this case, the best is the duality of control and support.
- **Supportive leader:** less controlling, offering more emotional support, encouragement and participation when the learner already has basic competencies but still needs motivation and self-confidence.
- **Delegating leader:** when the student is able to complete the task independently and confidently, and the leader tends to withdraw, his role is more concerned with supervision and strengthening independence, he does not direct or support, he only observes and is available.

If the teacher is aware of these leadership styles, it can make the learning journey of the students very smooth.

Aggression management

In situational leadership, the issue of control must be handled in a situation-dependent and conscious

16 https://gyurecsaba.eu/vezetesi-stilusok-a-szituativ-vezetes/

manner. Aggression management should be thought through in the same way. On the curriculum page, we have already dealt with the fact that pedagogy has already cultivated non-violent tools that can handle difficult situations in a gentle way. Let us now look at the causes and manifestations, as well as the teachers' reactions to them.

1. **Introverted, low-intensity aggression:** when a child is timid, shy, withdrawn, insecure, lacking self-confidence, aggression appears in a mild form, turning inward. The adult's task in this case is to motivate and encourage. The emphasis is on strengthening the sense of security, supporting initiative and increasing self-efficacy.
2. **Introverted, high-intensity aggression and depressive state** often manifest itself in apathy, passivity, and emotional isolation. The teacher can turn to the student with energization and cautious activation. The goal is to gradually help the child into a state where aggression can appear outward and in a more constructive way – this is an important step in development.
3. **Outward, high-intensity aggression manifests itself in** destructive, antisocial and relationship-violating behaviour. In such cases, consistent discipline can help in addition to acceptance. It is important to provide clear frameworks, rules and boundaries, while the child also receives emotional acceptance.

The essence of situational leadership in pedagogy is that the degree of support, guidance and framing is always adjusted to the child's current state.

The safe atmosphere

The ECA teacher reacts to both hard and soft processes. Not only his feedback, but also his assignment of tasks and reactions during work affect both areas. The usual attitude is usually aimed at regulating hard processes: we monitor, direct, and give feedback on the actual task solution. In the ECA class, we do the same with the other areas that appear among the goals.

Teaching skills

The values of the person-centred approach were formulated by Carl Rogers: empathy, congruence, unconditional positive regard, trust and open communication.

The teacher focuses on the students' whole personality and individual development along these values. It respects students' interests, feelings, and pace while creating a safe and accepting learning atmosphere. It reflects attentively on students' expressions, encourages self-expression, and supports joint problem-solving, without wanting to control every step. This approach helps learners to develop based on their own experience and internal resources, thereby becoming more effective both personally and as learners.

The teacher should be able to recognize the individual needs and abilities of the students, thus ensuring an inclusive environment where each child can progress at their own pace. Empathy, patience and flexibility are essential to create an atmosphere of trust and effectively support students' independent learning and self-assessment. The essence of the person-centred approach is that the teacher is not only an information transmitter, but also a mentor and facilitator, who actively involves the student in the learning process, encouraging reflective thinking and creativity.

Person-centred skills

There is no need to elaborate at length on the unity of empathy and congruence. These closely related concepts are the depositories of our peace in the world. Empathy means being able to understand and empathize with the emotions and perspectives of others, thereby supporting understanding and compassion. Congruence means inner harmony, honesty and authenticity between our own emotions, thoughts and behaviour. For a teacher, the congruence is important in order to be able to connect authentically with the students, and empathy is important to be able to respond sensitively to their needs, thus promoting a sense of trust and security in the educational environment. Together, these skills contribute to the development of students' own emotional intelligence and social skills.

It is a great help that when the idea of the person-centred approach was born, Rogers narrowed down the number of values to five and focused on them. However, there are many other values in the line: cooperation, responsibility, respect, and so on. The easiest way to turn to the ECA program is for a teacher who already bases his or her life and teaching principles on humanistic values.

ECA Skills and Competences

The skills required to deliver a successful ECA program include effective communication and collaboration with different actors and differentiation that allows for different student needs to be met. Good problem-solving, conflict management and organizational skills are also important. These allow the teacher to choose the most appropriate methods and tools for the given situation. This is coupled with a commitment to continuous self-reflection and professional development, which ensures that teachers are always able to adapt to the changing learning and educational environment with the latest knowledge and practices.

Interactive teaching

Interactive tools not only add variety to the lesson, but also motivate students and promote active participation. Experiential, interactive learning imparts knowledge, and also develops critical thinking and collaboration skills, thereby contributing to successful and lasting learning outcomes.

Motivation

At the teacher training university, it is taught that motivation is the key to success. In the previous sections, we have been dealing with the fact that motivation as a teaching activity becomes unnecessary. If we think about natural learning, just look at the first six years of a small child – children create fantastic performance along the lines of self-motivation all along. They learn to walk, talk, regulate vegetative processes – they show tremendous progress week by week. Under the right circumstances, their emotional regulation is also based on empathy and correct self-expression. They understand when grandma is sad or the puppy is afraid. And they are able to work steadfastly for 15 hours a day. We don't have to grade them for this, they instinctively go their own way without praise. It is very noticeable if they get stuck somewhere in this process and need medical or other help. They usually live and develop on their own, relying on that certain desired inner motivation.

Where will all this go in school? How does a child become able to go home after the first day with the disappointment that "... and will this go on for another 12 years?" Why do many children lose their desire to go to school by the end of the first year? The essence of what we have to say is: let them go their own way, at their own pace. Give only as much help as they need, when they indicate it. Don't push or pull them. Do not make them make more effort than they give by themselves.

However, we know that it is impossible to organize this with a large number of people. So we say: well, let's shape the school so that as many young students as possible can be present. What do they need most to thrive? Companions (both adults and peers), time and choices. ECA provides this: emotional and social competences to be GOOD together, knowledge bases to understand the world and activities around us, to feel good.

One of the motivational theories of adults is associated with David McClelland[17], who identified three main types of motivations: performance, power, and relational motivation.

The teacher may strive to identify and encourage individual motivation types in students at an early stage. From a practical point of view, this can be achieved, for example, by encouraging performance-oriented children with tasks in which they can experience a sense of achievement and receive development opportunities. In the case of children motivated to power, it is important to assign leadership roles and responsibilities, for example in group work, where they can be given directing and coordinating tasks. And for children with relationship motivation, community activities and tasks that require cooperation offer reinforcement. This way, the educator can develop personalized motivational strategies that support students.

Treatment of the individual

Change Management[18]

The teacher must know that resistance to change is a natural part of the process. Rogers states that

17 https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/David_McClelland
18 https://promanconsulting.hu/valtozasmenedzsment/

essential learning involves personality change and is therefore threatening. A major change requires a deeper self-understanding and behavioural modification. If the teacher is familiar with Conner's change curve, he or she can minimize difficulties by accompanying students with more patience.

Pyramid of Dilts[19]

Another theory that can help the teacher's understanding and influence his or her classroom solutions.

The Dilts model is a useful tool for the teacher in managing young students. It shows where you can intervene effectively in solving learning or behavioural problems. According to this theory, at the bottom of the pyramid, the teacher can achieve change at the level of the environment, circumstances, behaviour (e.g. discipline) and abilities (e.g. reading skills) through external intervention, the introduction of a new routine or individual tasks. Beliefs and values, identity or mission can no longer have a direct effect on the levels. Here, the teacher can take on a more supportive role.

Flow[20]

Unlike the previous ones, this theory is also well known in pedagogy. The teacher's efforts in the ECA program are actually aimed at creating the well-known flow state.

A toddler's learning performance is best when their tension and excitement levels are neither too low nor too high, but "just enough" – that is, they are in a safe position and face just enough challenges. For example, it can look like offering several variations of difficulty levels for the same task and allowing the child to choose the one that suits their own "zone". You can break down the curriculum into short, success-giving steps, and there are many other ways to create the Flow experience. In addition to encouragement, the teacher should pay attention to the signs (disorientation, restlessness, crying) that indicate that someone is slipping out of the optimal lane. This is how the teacher can consciously create a learning environment where a child can concentrate, try and develop in the best possible way.

Manage your group

There are a few principles that can be important for a teacher to think about. Some of these are based on Rogers' insights, while others are born from the experience of those who practice person-centeredness. In the ECA system, we formulated these as self-reflective questions. The teacher working in the ECA approach consciously undertakes a non-directive presence. He is able to wait patiently for slowly forming solutions, even if they are not yet fully visible. He accepts that processes have their own time and that his role is often not to intervene, but – among other things – to support the processing of events that have happened.

In the event of a conflict, the teacher, in his role as interpreter and mediator, listens impartially to all members of the group. He offers his own opinion, but does not insist that it should be decisive. He says that his presence should provide security and that the participants can feel free to share their thoughts and feelings.

Non-violence is the foundation of the ECA teacher's attitude. The teacher strives to maintain inner calm even when he encounters provocative or astonishing opinions. He tries to react gently instead of angrily, to give reflective answers that do not close the dialogue, but further open it. And striving often leads to success.

The quality of attention is key. The teacher is able to notice the subtle turning points that indicate a change of direction in the functioning of the group. He also has the courage to say what the members of the group cannot or do not dare to say yet.

Acceptance means that the teacher realizes that not every situation leads to a closed solution. It is often enough to take a single step forward and accept that the process itself can be more valuable than the outcome.

In addition to all this, the ECA teacher is an active participant. He knows when and in what he needs to be actively present and recognizes situations where he can make real progress. His taskis not management, but a responsible presence that serves the development of the group.

19 https://farkasdezso.hu/dilts-piramis/
20 https://hu.wikipedia.org/wiki/Flow-%C3%A9lm%C3%A9ny

Group dynamics

We dwell on this concept for a longer time, we discuss it in more detail, because it is a topic that affects every teacher and class teacher, yet we usually learn little and know little about theoretical approaches, even though the literature approaches the topic from several angles.

The teacher is a key player in shaping group dynamics. He or she is responsible for creating the conditions in which students feel safe and accepted. The teacher monitors the interactions of the group members, intervenes if necessary, and supports cooperation, conflict management and strengthening group cohesion. His job is to promote open communication, a balance of roles, and help group members set and achieve common goals.

There are several theories of group dynamics that can help the teacher's work. The Schattenhofer pendulum has already been mentioned. Let us now look at one of the most well-known formal group development models, the Tuckman model.[21] This theory identifies four main stages in the formation of a group: Forming – Storming – Norming – Performing. The four distinct periods help you understand how a group develops through personal and group challenges, from coming together to working together effectively. Knowledge of these phases is essential for teachers, as it allows them to recognize changes in group dynamics in time.

Another help could be Schindler's[22] model of rank dynamics. It's about the basic roles of the group, which are at different hierarchical levels. Alpha members are usually the dominant, leading individuals who control the group. Opposite them are the Omegas, who represent a part of the group, while the "Gamma" members are more supportive, cooperative actors who contribute to the stability and harmony of the group. Finally, the Betas are the representatives of the expert, knowledge side. With the insight of the teacher, he can recognize the operation of the group forces and indirectly influence the strong influence of the constructive forces on the group at the level of values.

There are many more theories of group dynamics. With their help, the teacher is much easier to react with patience and expertise, to provide the appropriate framework for the group, and to push the children forward to a more harmonious situation in the moment of blockages. Since the ECA system creates more dynamic situations than a traditional classroom, the knowledge of group dynamics can be used to gain new useful skills.

Conflict management

Similarly, early detection and prevention of conflicts, as well as sensitive management of participants' emotions and needs, are among the primary tasks of the teacher if they are striving to create a safe and accepting learning atmosphere. It can do a lot for the openness of communication, it can set a model for active listening and empathetic understanding, following and interpreting all parties involved. It is also his job to encourage constructive solutions and to create the conditions for it. At the same time, the teacher must set an example of respectful behaviour and, if necessary, provide effective strategic and behavioural frameworks for processing conflicts. In this way, he can help students develop their independent conflict management skills, for example, through emotional self-regulation and the use of problem-solving techniques.

Relationship clarification

It takes a lot of time, but the movement of the group is absolutely determined by whether a teacher can solve personal conflicts and group problems. It is important to manage relationship clarifications as both prevention and crisis management. There are two practical approaches to it: feedback, and mediation. Much has already been said about feedback, its formal and substantive elements, let's take a closer look at mediation.

Mediation

The teacher's task during mediation is to act as a neutral mediator to help those involved in the conflict to understand each other's point of view so that they can find a solution together. To this end, it is important to prepare consciously, which also includes learning about the principles of mediation. Due to the complex nature of the topic, it is worth participating in a separate training, because it is only in real life or in situational exercises that simulate it that we can most easily get a feel for the thousands

21 https://teamguide.hu/a-csoportfejlodes-szakaszai/?srsltid=AfmBOoobhs_thblySllKoB1t9n3nMbGBF-i2x40ulOAZeGgSu5IoB4nn
22 https://drive.google.com/file/d/1sJ86ncbWJfV6Rb-4NznynBuu0g6ICfY8/view

of different manifestations of the desired attitude. It is important for the teacher to constantly develop his self-reflection and empathy, as well as to learn to stay in difficult emotional situations. With these skills, he is able to maintain impartiality and promote the birth of constructive solutions.

If we wanted to develop a competency profile for these, we would find the following:

- Ability to create an atmosphere of trust
- Supporting the growth of others
- Detect and highlight the smallest progress
- Awareness of incentive behaviour
- Ability to achieve reconciliation
- Assessing diversity
- Openness to new things

Restorative conflict management[23]

This is also a common way of conflict resolution, similar to mediation. Here, too, the teacher performs the task of holding the frames for the situation. Without judgment, let us ask the four questions: What happened? Who is affected? How are the actors involved? Who has to do what?

Betrayal and legitimate complaint

However, there is a situation when the teacher has to make judgment. When a child turns to her about a partner, she must distinguish between relationship-destroying betrayal and a real request for help, and treat both as parenting situations. So the judgment is not about the child, but about the situation. He must recognize why the child turns to her: does he want to exercise power or does he indicate real hurt or insecurity? In this case, the teacher does not immediately judge, but asks, interprets and helps the child to put his feelings and needs into words. In the event of a legitimate complaint, it provides security and takes responsibility for resolving the situation; and in the case of betrayal, it supports direct communication and conflict management. Thus, the decision is not about discipline, but about emotional and social learning.

Teacher's self-development

The person-centred approach is not a method, but an approach, a worldview. And it is not possible to prepare for this quickly and easily, it takes years to learn this.

Training opportunities, books

Today, there are several trainings that help those who want to get to know the person-centeredness more deeply. The following are specifically recommended for teachers. If someone wants to get acquainted with the basics of person-centeredness as a teacher, they will find more than one useful reading in the detailed bibliography. We recommend the books of Carl Rogers and Thomas Gordon in particular.

- In Hungary, the **Rogers Centre** is one of the training institutions: https://www.roger-skozpont.hu/
- **The Gordon TA coach and trainer training organization** approaches person-centredness from the attitude-level, following in the footsteps of Zsuzsa F. Várkonyi, providing trainings for professionals and laymen alike: https://gordonta.hu/rolunk/
- In the same way, the **Rogers Centre** (https://www.rogerskozpont.hu/) also organizes e.g. encounter and counseling groups for attitude training.
- **The Gordon Institute Budapest** also deals with trainings. This training organization is closer to the practical side. This is where you can come if you want to get practical training as a parent, teacher or manager: https://www.gordontrening.hu/

Supervision

Like all helping professionals, teachers also need ventilation and discussion of professional issues. So right at the beginning of the process, it is good to find a fellow teacher, colleague or professional helper who can provide effective support in difficult times.

Before we embark on the person-centred and ECA approach, it is worth being aware of what Carl Rogers says about the transfer of control: if we decide to hand over the "power", we must persevere in the moment of difficulty. From now on, we plan and implement everything in the spirit of partnership: learning organization, methodology, assessment and everything else. We renounce control based on

23 https://konszenzus.org/wp-content/uploads/AVR/lecke6_lap1.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com

strength and hierarchy and let go of instructions, rewards, punishments, and many other things that we traditionally consider to be the teacher's job and responsibility. So we need to know if we are really ready to see the child as a partner.

Door to the upper school

This curriculum provides a framework for the ECA-based operation of the lower school (grade 1-4). A separate material will be prepared for grades 4–8, which seeks to answer the question of how the approach and practice developed here can be transferred to subject teaching, to the world of multi-teacher classes, and how to support children in preserving and developing the autonomy, self-knowledge and community competences experienced in ECA in upper school. Here are some of the areas that arise:

- **Curriculum:** not much and not big, but all the more important changes are needed. We need to transform the systems without which ECA would remain an island with more teachers and a more complex curriculum. Such is primarily emotion – and, if it is acceptable, environmental content dealing with sustainability.
- **School-level time management:** flexible blocks (90-minute ECA cycles), project weeks, introduction of inter-subject integration so that the subjects do not break motivation but build on the inner drive.
- **Institutional traditions adapted to local characteristics:** holidays, events, headteacher classes can be transformed in the ECA spirit – e.g. with democratic decision-making practices, where children are actively involved in the planning of community programs (which is still the case in many schools).
- **Teacher teamwork:** horizontal learning (joint lesson planning, supervision, ECA workshops), where teachers work together for classes with a facilitator attitude, creating a unified EQ and assessment culture.
- **Institutional framework of parental partnership:** common evaluation language (portfolio presentations, narrative feedback), trust-building forums where parents also understand and support the development of autonomy.

This is how a powerful, full-school ECA program is born, which retains motivation, emotional safety and a sense of community in the midst of the challenges of upper school. So ECA can go beyond a department and later be further developed at the institutional level.

Implementing ECA in its full professional depth as a school-level program requires serious learning by the teaching staff; however, a teacher can introduce the ECA approach into his or her own class in an authentic and effective way, and this is also a valuable start. It is not a requirement that everyone starts this program at the same time. One of the advantages of the program is that the curriculum is not based on unrealistic structural changes, i.e. there is no need for a new framework curriculum or a local curriculum. It primarily brings a change in approach, time management and evaluation; this increases the chances of it being introduced. At the same time, it is important that what the school officially undertakes as an ECA curriculum has the minimum level of common knowledge and coordination (time frame, assessment, parental communication, local adaptation). This can also be achieved in successive steps: after an individual teacher starts, small teams can be formed. When this is already available in several classes or grades, it can also be launched as a school-level program.

Loving with open hands

Finally, here is a metaphor that expresses the essence of the person-centred approach more than anything else.

Ruth Sanford: "Loving with open hands"[24]

"When I was talking to a friend this week, I remembered a story I heard over the summer. A compassionate man who saw a butterfly struggling to free itself from its cocoon gently loosened the cocoon's wall with the intention of helping to open the way for it. The butterfly broke free, emerged from the cocoon, flapped its

24 https://www.facebook.com/rogerskozpont/posts/ruth-sanford-nyitott-k%C3%A9zzel-szeretni-amikor-ezen-a-h%C3%A9ten-egy-bar%C3%A1tommal-besz%C3%A9lge/1258329017887852/ – Published in The Observer. Translated by Magda Draskóczy

wings, but could not fly. This compassionate man did not know that it was only during the struggle of birth that the wings were strengthened and made fit to fly. The butterfly spent a short life on earth – it never knew freedom, it never really lived."

I would say that you have to learn to love with open hands. For me, it was a slow learning process, between the fire of pain and tears of patience. I learnt that I have to let go of the one I love, because if I hold on to them, hold them tightly, want to limit them, control them, then I will lose them.

If I try to change the person I love because I feel that I know what they should be like, then I am robbing them of their precious right, the right to take responsibility for their own life, for their decisions, for the way they live. Whenever I impose my will or desire on them, or try to exercise power over them, I deprive them of the opportunity to fully experience their own growth and maturation. No matter how good my intentions may be, I limit and hinder them with my actions.

Even the best intentions of protection can limit and hurt, and overprotection and care can say to others more eloquently than any words: "You are incapable of taking care of yourself, I have to take care of you because you are mine. I am responsible for you."

As a result of learning and practicing, I can say to the one I love: "I love you, I appreciate you, I respect you, and I trust that you are strong enough or can become strong enough to accomplish all that is possible for you in life – if I do not stand in your way. I love you so much that I can let you go, so that you can walk by my side in joy and sorrow. I'm going to share your tears, but I'm not asking you not to cry. I will care for your needs, I will take care of you, and I will help you, but I will not pick you up when you can walk alone. I am ready to be with you in your grief and loneliness, but I will not take the grief and loneliness away from you. I will try to listen to your words and their deeper meaning, but I will not always agree with you.

Sometimes I will be angry, and when I am angry, I will try to express it openly so that we do not have to resent being different and do not have to be alienated from each other. I can't always be with you and hear what you're saying, because there is a time when I have to pay attention to myself and take care of myself. When that happens, I'll be as honest with you as I can."

I learn to express it, either in words or in the way I live with those I love, care for, and myself. This is what I call love with open hands.

I can't always keep my hands away from the cocoon, but I do it more and more often!"

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